Drawn Into The Music

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25993432.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Celebrity, Alternate Universe - Popstar, Fluff, Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Paparazzi, Hurt/Comfort, Social Media, Modern AU but still Canon Species

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Catradora AUs by n7punk

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Summary

"Adora," Bow calls from a few feet ahead of her , having continued on while she was cornered by a fan, *thanks Bow*, "come meet your co-star!" he calls. Adora looks up, making eye contact with a split gaze, and promptly drops her unwanted coffee.
"Hey , Adora."
(Popstar Adora/Actress Catra getting back together in a Modern Celebrity AU)
Edit : Fic edited on 21/4/21 with a final epilogue chapter added (originally completed 28/8/20).

The Award Show (to the start where the end awaits)

Chapter Notes

> This is a popstar AU with some idol influence. Bright Moon Entertainment is a record company that puts all its act together from individual auditions. They train together for a little while before their debut and then release albums every year or two. Some helpful terms: "Craft (services)" is essentially the food on a film shoot. A "treatment" is like a screenplay for a music video. "Line distribution" is how much screen/singing time each member gets in a song. BME = Bright Moon Entertainment. EDIT: I've edited this fic in April of 2021 (originally completed August 2020), making minor changes (the story is the same). I've left a lot of the author's notes intact, and some scenes/chapters have barely changed while others are more buffed out.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After so long, Adora sees her again at an award show. Rebellion's second album is up for five awards. Adora is anxious about the album's reception at the show already, even without the possibility of running into someone infinitely more important than some record. *Heatstings* quickly became a number one hit, but it has only been out for two months now and she is protective of the album that is so personal to her.

She is nervous for the album, but her main focus for the night isn't if they will win any of their nominations. Perfuma is attending the show as a member of Rebellion and Scorpia is attending as a member of Frght-Z. That means neither of them are using their plus ones on each other – it would be a little soon, anyway, considering they *just* started dating – and that leaves Scorpia free to use her invite on a friend - her best friend.

Adora's best friend, once upon a time. And more – a lot more. When Adora catches sight of Catra curled around Scorpia's arm, chuckling at something Entrapta said, her heart does a flip. She manages to catch Catra's eye and she blinks in shock at her, almost like she hadn't been prepared for Adora to actually be attending the show. Adora wrote an entire album for her, but she still feels like the volume of her words threatens to burst out of her chest as they stare at each other across the infinite gap between them.

Catra's ear twitches and she turns away to say something to her friends. Her face, at least from this distance, is blank and impassive, but she *is* an actress. Adora knows well how deeply Catra can bury her feelings. That was how this chasm grew between them in the first place, *something* growing in Catra until she couldn't stand to stay any longer. Adora needs to speak to her, but she doubts she could get close enough to say a word if she tried to approach directly.

It isn't until Adora is on stage for the fourth time that night, accepting the final award that she possibly can, that she works up the nerve to say only a fraction of her emotions.

"This album is a love letter to my one true muse. There are ups and downs in it, but that is a part of life and how our story has always gone," Adora says into the microphone as she takes the final award they are nominated for and holds it close to her chest, clutching to it just a bit. The rest of Rebellion is crowded around her, Glimmer's arm thrown over her shoulders. *Heartstrings* might be Adora's album, but they all have been taking turns accepting their awards.

Adora goes last. Everybody knows how she is with handling the press, but Adora also has something she *needs* to say. As they approached the stage, no one questioned it when she whispered *let me take this one, guys*. She does not dare to glance at the section of the audience where Frght-Zs seated as she finishes, "Thank you for every moment. You will always be my heart."

Adora raises the award and then walks off the stage, Rebellion crowded around her, with her chest pounding. She already knows Angella is going to be pulling her aside the second the cameras shut off, but she doesnt care. All she can think about is getting to the afterparty and praying Catra has stuck around.

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When Adora makes her way into the afterparty, she is shocked to find Catra has, in fact, stayed. Even better, she's *alone*, leaned up against a wall in a relatively quiet corner, a full drink loose in her hand. Adora knows her - it's more of a prop than anything else. It's almost like she is inviting Adora to talk to her, coming to the show and then giving them the opportunity for a private moment like this.

Adora approaches cautiously, dodging a few people who wave at her. Catra watches her approach out of the corner of her eye, her expression unreadable as Adora walks straight into what could very well be a trap. She pauses when she reaches Catra, unsure of what to say. Catra fixes her gaze to the left, looking out the bay windows and into the night.

"Subtle," she comments on the show. Adora snorts, feeling herself relax a little. Catra isnt *mad* about her speech at least. Cautiously, she takes a step closer. Catra's tail flicks, a single lash from side to side, but her claws dont unsheathe and she doesnt comment, so it seems Adora is still far enough away. She wants to walk right up and squeeze Catra against her chest - it has been almost a *year and a half* since she last saw Catra - but she knows she cant step closer without risking her bolting.

"If you let my calls through, I might have been able to use a more delicate approach," Adora answers. She inwardly winces - too much, probably. Especially given the shit she just pulled on stage. To her

shock, Catra *sighs*. She finally turns away from the window and meets Adora's eyes. Adora is even more surprised to see a storm of emotions in Catra's gaze. Catra could hide it if she wanted to and the vulnerability of letting Adora see how she is feeling – however indecipherable it is – takes Adora's breath away after all this time.

"I listened to the album. Look, Adora, you haven't changed and we both know it," she tells her, expression tired as she watches Adora's reaction to that. Adora feels like she is in shock. The sentiment isn't surprising, it is *true*, but the implication contained within it is staggering.

"What, so if I get better at taking care of myself, you'll talk to me again?" she asks, stunned. Catra actually laughs, an almost *hopeful* light dancing in her eyes as she looks away briefly before making eye contact again. She looks absolutely exhausted, like she is too tired to even put up her mask. Her tail is limp, her shoulders slumped as she leans back against the wall for support.

"Yeah, we'll get back together when you learn your career isn't the most important thing in this world. The day you take a vacation is the day I call you back," Catra promises, disbelief clear in her voice. She looks like she is already waiting for Adora to fail her again. Without another word, she pushes off the wall, and Adora is too stunned to do anything but watch her go.

The last year has been the most painful of Adora's life, and that is *saying* something considering what her first nineteen had been like when she had Catra at her side. Adora has struggled to find happiness and stability without Catra. Her music has suffered too, to the point where their producer, Casta, jokingly offered to have her ex kidnapped so Adora could have her inspiration back.

That was what spurred Adora to write from her memories of Catra, pouring out an entire album just about them. The new material became their second album, and it ended up being record-breaking, but all that success doesn't mean a thing without Catra. Adora

started down this path because she loved music, true, but she *sacrificed* herself for it because she wanted to provide for them.

What good was all the success in the world if she couldn't even have Catra by her *side*? Catra has made an offer and, like or not, Adora is going to take it to heart. It might not be a real chance, but it is her first glimpse of one in a year and a half.

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"I want to take a vacation," Adora says six weeks later, watching the entire room fall silent in response. Her bandmates turn in unison and stare at her, along with their manager. She does her best not to fidget her hands beneath the conference table—it is glass so it wouldn't offer any protection anyway, but the urge is there. She *hates* asking for things for herself.

"Y-ou- I had to have heard that wrong," Glimmer says, despite being seated right beside her, staring at her with wide eyes. Adora winces, slouching down in her seat a little-

"Adora, we would *love* for you to take a vacation," Perfuma assures from across the table. Adora sends her a thankful smile, but it is small. The word still feels wrong. "I think we're just surprised. In the last two years, you have never taken time off. Even after the *hospital*," Perfuma clarifies. Half the table winces.

"Both times," Bow adds. Adora huffs, but she catches Bow's eye and he looks *pained*. She glances over to their manager. Angella just gives her an encouraging smile. Slowly, Adora sits up in her seat and squares her shoulders like she is preparing for battle. This shouldn't be a fight with her friends, but it is with *herself*.

"I know you guys have asked me to take time off before. I know there were times when I needed it more, but I really can't think of a better time than now. I was thinking of taking two weeks in a month or so, right before we film the music video for *Bad End*. Maybe going on a retreat or something, just focus on music and myself for a bit," Adora tells them.

Her fellow band members look varying levels of proud, Perfuma and Bow in near tears while Mermista remains largely aloof aside from a spark in her eyes. Glimmer is biting her lip and looking at Adora with shining eyes. Frosta looks a bit confused – she only just joined the group for their third album to fill the space Entrapta left when she switched to Frght-Z after their debut, so she has not been witness to Adora's last three collapses from overworking.

"I would love for you to be well-rested for the single release, Adora. The only question is how we are going to arrange the shoot," Angella points out. Adora wants to wince. She always has her hands all over these things. As the leader and the group's songwriter, she is often the focus of them. She is a terrible actress, and the only way she knows to face an unsure situation is overplanning and strategizing.

Leaving it to others feels like shoving off responsibility onto someone else, but she knows there is one member who has had an interest in directing since before Rebellion was even formed. Adora glances hopefully to her left, where Bow is sitting. Bow catches her eye and understands her immediately. He leans forward excitedly.

"I would *love* to take it," he promises her. Adora breathes a sigh of relief, sending him a thankful look. Despite it being her song, Bow was the one who wrote the treatment that they settled on for this music video. It was the first one that he wrote completely solo, and it feels right to step back and let him direct it to ensure that it comes out the way that he wants it to.

"Are you sure you're okay with this, Adora?" Perfuma asks, glancing between them. "I know this song is important to you," she adds. She barely knows a fraction of its importance, but the entire group can tell

it has significance, even if Adora has been tightlipped about it. She nods. "The song *is* important to her, it might even end up being the most important song of her career, but-

"If I want the song to be more than wishful thinking, I have to do this," Adora returns. She gets a few raised brows, but before anyone can ask, Angella nods her approval. She knows more than the others do – she has to, if she is going to handle a PR situation – and Adora is grateful for her quick intervention.

"Then start looking at vacation destinations," Angella says.

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Adora knows she shouldn't be this unused to pulling up to shoots feeling *rested* and ready to take on the day. Shoot days are always challenging and it should be standard for her to be going into them at a hundred percent so she can effectively handle them. Unfortunately, she hasn't been at a hundred percent in two years, if *ever*.

"You look well," Angela praises as Adora steps out of the SUV sent to pick her up from the airport. Adora beams at her despite the early hour. When she first planned this, she didn't think she would be cutting her return so close to shooting, but she is glad for the extra time out in nature.

"I am as anxious as expected, but I feel good," Adora replies as Angella starts to lead her around the street barriers blocking off their filming location. No paparazzi in sight yet – maybe they will get through a public music video shoot in peace for once. They have rented out the entire fair ground for the day and there really is no reason for anyone to come down its entrance road and find out Bright Moon Entertainment is filming here today.

"I am proud of you for taking time like you have, Adora. Bow has really stepped up and taken care of the shoot details in your absence," Angella promises her . A PA comes running up to them, a tray of coffees in her hand and smiling anxiously at Adora as she holds them out. She is either a fan or just has been pre-warned about how tired Adora tends to be on these shoots. Adora sends her a small smile and takes one of the recycled cups just to be polite.

She doesn't need it - the ten-day writing retreat really did wonders for her. She wrote a lot while in the mountains, but it still felt like a breath of relief. Besides, she is *always* writing. She has hopped out of the shower to write down lyrics before. Calling it a writing retreat just made it easier for her accept it than if she referred to it as a vacation;calling it a retreat made it possible for her to finally follow Catra's instructions.

Adora is not, actually, expecting Catra to just call her back, no matter what she said at the party, but she and Catra are going to run into each other more now that Perfuma and Scorpia are getting serious. Adora is trying to be realistic about her chances, but she knows they are *zero* if she does not fix what tore them apart in the first place. Even if they don't get back together , there isn't a single person in the world that Adora wants in her life – *back* in her life – more than Catra.

Adora can recognize that her career came first, even if the reason was *for* Catra. Adora didn't want fame – she wanted to provide for them so they could be safe and happy together. The problem was the *happy* part. Adora had been busy ever since BME put together Rebellion, but when she was hospitalized from running herself into the ground on their first press tour, it had been too much for Catra. She had already been holding in her fears for a long time, it turned out.

"You can kill yourself for this if you want to. I don't have to watch it happen. I'm tired of seeing the woman I love in pain," Catra told her a day after she was released, when Adora told her she was going to get back to work the next day . It was the first time Catra said she

loved her like that – and the last. Catra walked out of their shitty , hole-in-the-wall apartment and straight out of Adora's life.

Maybe Catra wasn't sincere at the party , but Adora has to *try* . She has been pulling back in the three months since, trusting far more of the group's details to Glimmer and Bow and all the members of Rebellion's team. Nothing has collapsed so far. Their streams aren't dropping off any more than is expected with the time passed since their last release and there hasn't been a fire, not even when Sea Hawk came to the studio to visit Mermista.

Adora told Angella the truth when she arrived on-location. She is anxious - she fidgeted the whole car ride to the shoot location - but her time resting has done her good and made her even more confident in what she is doing. She trusts Bow. This shoot is his baby and she is honestly excited to see what he has planned out. He made her feel better by including her in costuming, sending her his final drafts and letting her veto things that were far too *Bow* for her. She loved him, but she doesn't *dress* like him.

"We'll be in the House of Mirrors for the performance shots first. Your lead and the background actors for the story scenes will be coming in after breakfast," Angella informs her as she pulls her towards hair and makeup. "Let's get you dressed up."

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Music video shoots are always hard on Adora. She usually manages to push off being too much of a focus by making arguments about line distribution, but since she was so uninvolved in this shoot, she didn't have the opportunity to. The video is mostly story , starring her. Even worse, *End* is a love song. She wrote it after the award show. It is about a lover who lost her way coming back to her other half and finding herself again.

t is what Catra would call *bedroom eyes*, but she would say it with a small smile on her face. f Catra listens to it, there is no way she wont know this song is for her . t makes Adora anxious, but the distance she has had from the shoot eases her a little. Even if Catra doesnt ask, word will make its way through the chain of friends, ex-group members, and girlfriends that Adora did not plan out this shoot. f anything is *too much*, aside from the song itself, she can push blame off on Bow.

"I cant believe how much screen time you gave me. Y ou know how bad I am at this," Adora whines to Bow as they walk out of the wardrobe trailer together. Bow has put her in maybe the dykiest muscle shirt and patch-covered boyfriend jeans that he could find. Bow rolls his eyes, but he puts a semi-sympathetic arm around her shoulders.

"How can you have a love song without *love*?" he asks, steering her towards the concrete parking lot that houses the fair's food trucks. "Come on, I spoke with Angella while you were getting changed. Your love interest finished with the hairstylist and is waiting by craft. Let's introduce her to your particular brand of acting, yeah?" Adora groans.

"I havent taken out my contacts yet," she complains, but she lets Bow lead her around. t has always been her policy to never explain why she doesnt wear them for shoots like this.

"W e dont start actually filming for another thirty minutes. Y ou have time," Bow placates. Adora grumbles a little as she lets herself be pulled along, but she doesnt push the point. She doesnt want to say *it's easier if I never see her*. Her casting requirements for anybody she is supposed to act alongside as a love interest have already raised enough eyebrows.

The second they get within eyeshot of craft services, the P A from earlier that morning pops up, smiling brightly as she hands Adora another coffee without asking. Adora never even finished the first

one, abandoning it on a vanity over in makeup. She isn't big on coffee unless she needs it and she really doesn't today.

"Uh-" Adora manages, looking between the girl and the coffee. *Definitely* an overeager fan, then. The girl continues to smile at her, but Adora can see panic setting in underneath the façade. She just wanted to be helpful, Adora reasons - to have a moment of connection with an idol. "Thanks," she manages, sheepishly, taking the coffee from her. The grin on the girl's face turns genuine as she beams, bowing a little to her before backing away.

"Adora," Bow calls from a few feet ahead of her, having continued on while she was cornered by a fan, *thanks Bow,* "come meet your co-star!" he calls. Adora looks up, making eye contact with a split gaze, and promptly drops her unwanted coffee.

"Hey, Adora."

Chapter End Notes

> I know I already wrote a modern au where Catra leaves Adora and then they get back together. YOU know I already wrote said modern au. We both know we have been here before, but that didn't fucking stop me. Listen, I just wanted to play with paparazzi, okay? This one is a lot less angsty.
> Catra, Adora, & Glimmer are 21 and Bow is 22. Frosta is 16. The other members of Rebellion & Frght-Z are all mid-to-late twenties.

The Music Video

Chapter Summary

> I'm her muse," Catra says, smirking and mildly delighted. Adora watches the dawning realization on Angella's face and the downright horror on Bow's.

Chapter Notes

> This AU is gonna move at breakneck speed so buckle your asses in.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora gapes at Catra, standing poised and smirking with her hand on her hip. The tight pink miniskirt that wardrobe gave her limits her tail's movement as it swishes in amusement from below the hem. She looks far too satisfied by Adora's shock. Adora is still staring, lukewarm coffee splashed all over the leg of her thankfully-black jeans, her brain in an overdrive of *how* and *why*.

"I admit, I really thought you arranged this," Catra tells her, strolling forward and glancing at the puddle around her feet with a downright smug smirk. Adora's shock isn't abating, but the words work their way deep enough into her brain for her to fully process for the first time that Catra is here as one of their actors – specifically, as the one playing her *love interest.*

"I- uh- I was on vacation," Adora manages to stammer. Her mouth is still hanging open, but she is working on taking baby steps towards regaining coherency. *Like you wanted*, she doesn't say. She isn't quite stable enough for it yet. Catra quirks an eyebrow at her, her smirk softening down to a true smile now.

"I heard," she responds, her voice a bit lower and just a touch *rough*. Adora's heart pounds in her throat. *Is that why you took the job*, she

doesn't manage to ask. Her mouth is working about as well as her brain, right now.

"You two know each other?" Angella's voice comes floating in, attempting to break the spell that has overtaken Adora. She is looking at nothing but Catra. Catra's eyes are bright and appraising as she, in turn, looks at nothing but Adora. Adora is not sure when Angella got here, but her voice sounds nearby. Close enough to overhear, clearly.

Adora forces herself to finally tear her eyes away from Catra, finding Angella standing only a few feet away from Bow and narrowing her eyes at Catra as if she is a threat to be appraised. Adora has to cut this off before Angella starts running a background check – it has happened before and it will happen again. Angella knows enough to be rightfully protective of Adora, but Catra is not a part of her past she needs to be worrying about.

"Yeah, we do. Um, meet Catra, guys. She's my-" Adora cuts off, realizing she does not know *what* Catra is, much less what Catra wants her bandmates and manager to know her as. She sends a desperate look to Catra, and it may have been a year, but the two of them can still communicate without words. Catra understands Adora's question and her lips twitch in amusement, but she turns to face Angella so she can address her.

"I'm her *one*," Catra says, smirking, with delight dancing in her eyes. Adora watches the dawning realization on Angella's face and the downright *horror* on Bow's. Catra used to roll her eyes when Adora called her that, but she always smiled softly when Adora argued it sounded more romantic than *girlfriend* or *partner*. It was the exact kind of sappiness that Catra pretended to be above but secretly luxuriated in.

"*You're* Heartstrings?" Bow almost *cries*, voice strangled and loud enough to attract the attention of several other crewmembers that are loitering nearby. They are, mercifully, still far enough away to not

actually understand the distraught words. Adora doesnt need to be descended on when she is still recovering from her shock.

"That is what the band decided to call the – *inspiration* behind our Heartstrings album," Adora rushes to clarify , stepping around the coffee puddle to place a hand on Catra's shoulder almost on instinct. She hasnt touched her in almost two years and it feels profound, not only to do, but that Catra doesnt *react* to it. She just accepts the touch, still reveling in the chaos she has caused by *being* .

Catra sends her a slightly relieved look. Adora knows it is a silent thank you for continuing to keep her details so private that the other members didnt even know the name of the girl they were singing about. They both agreed to keep the details of their personal lives private and Adora never would have broken that agreement, even after the breakup, but she accepts the thanks with a small smile.

"Not all of them are about me," Catra argues, looking back over to Bow. "Parallel is on that album," she adds. Adora turns bright red in an instant. Catra notices, because of *course* she does. For the first time since this encounter began, she is thrown off, openly staring at Adora. She recovers much quicker than Adora, however .

"Adora, you never *said* ," she purrs, ear flicking in amusement. Adora becomes aware of the fact that Frosta has made her way within earshot and that Perfuma, Mermista, and Glimmer are not far behind. The last thing she wants to do is discuss the closest thing to a sex song that she has ever released where Frosta can hear . If Frosta had been a part of the group back then, Adora guarantees she wouldnt have even considered putting it on the album.

"Can we *please* not talk about this now? Here, specifically?" she asks, looking *anywhere* but at the people she works with every day. Unfortunately, that leaves her looking at Catra, only a few inches from her. Catra's eyes are calculating as she sweeps her gaze slowly over Adora's body before focusing on her face.

Adora knows she must be bright red, but she does her best to hold Catra's gaze. Her expression softens. Adora practically feels like she is *fluttering* having Catra look at her like that again. She doesn't look tired – *depressed* - like she did back at the award show. Before Adora can get too excited over the softness in her gaze, Catra turns around, directing her attention back to Angella. Adora does her best to not let her disappointment show.

"Adora is a terrible actress on a *good* day. Can we get 30 minutes alone to talk before shooting? Otherwise she might pass out the second I touch her," Catra tells Angella, tail flicking as she speaks. Angella glances between them, looking to Adora for approval. Adora nods eagerly. She is not going to throw this opportunity away, not with Catra here somehow, preparing to act like she is *in love with her* again.

Adora feels a weird mix of hope, anxiety, and dawning horror at that realization. *Why* would Catra take this job? Especially thinking Adora had been the one to hire her?

"Filming is supposed to start in 20 minutes. I'll have them push it. Take your thirty in the trailer by the pier," Angella agrees, still watching Adora like she expects her to back out. Catra nods in confirmation, taking Adora's hand without having to ask or even look, leading her out of the loose circle of craft services and right past Glimmer and Mermista.

Glimmer mouths *what is going on?* to her while Mermista goes with *what the hell?* but Adora ignores them, solely focused on Catra's back before her. She hears a shrill exclamation from Frosta behind her and has no doubt Frosta has heard from Bow who is pulling Adora along.

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"When BME reached out to me, I really thought you had requested me," Catra tells her after a few moments in silence. Catra is leaned against the cabinets in the cramped trailer. Adora has chosen to press herself against a door on the opposite wall, needing the support. There is, at best, two feet of space between them. The lighting is terrible and the recycled air is stiff, but Catra still looks gorgeous in the yellow light.

"Why did you take the job, then?" Adora asks, pretending she can't hear how desperate her own voice is. She has to know. Catra shrugs, but Adora can tell it is one of her *distancing* shrugs, trying to downplay the importance of what she is about to say. It makes hope bloom in her chest.

"I asked Scorpia some questions as soon as I got the offer. I heard you were stepping back. I still thought you *knew*, it seemed like too much of a coincidence otherwise, but I had to see if it was true," she tells her, watching Adora's reaction carefully. Adora ignores the way her breath is catching. Catra- Catra is giving her a *chance*. She swallows, trying to gather herself before she responds.

"Catra, you were right, back at the party . I'm not expecting anything, it would be stupid to, but I'm– I want to *try* to be better for you," Adora tells her, too honestly, too much. Catra looks stricken, ears dropping and quickly looking away . Adora bites her bottom lip, cursing herself for saying the wrong thing, and waits. There is nothing else she can do – she told Catra the truth.

"The song?" Catra asks, still looking indistinctly away . She does not need to say more.

"Yeah," Adora sighs, raising her hand to run it through her hair before remembering she will ruin all the work her stylist did. "I wrote it after the party. When I committed to listening to you. It was, I don't know, like my pledge to follow through?" she explains, gesturing with her hands a bit instead before dropping them back down to her sides.

Catra's eyes find her, shining and full, but Adora does not know with *what*. She feels like her breath has been stolen away all over again. She may pass out from lack of oxygen at this point. It can't be good for her to go breathless so many times in one day. After several seconds of silence, Catra breaks the moment, looking down and reaching inside the varsity jacket wardrobe had given her.

She pulls out her old, cracked phone – the same one she bought when she was seventeen and they were dirt poor foster kids – and begins working away on it. Adora has no idea what that means – probably that Catra is mad at her. It might even be a hint for her to go now, the thirty minutes be damned. Catra used to do shit like this back at the foster home.

She would send a glare to one of the other kids and then ignore them until they gave up and left. Adora is not used to being on the receiving end of it. She was always an exception to Catra's moods. Catra glances up at her and sighs when she catches her expression, but she returns to looking down at her phone.

"I'm unblocking your number," she says, conversationally, like she is not throwing Adora into a typhoon without a life raft. If Adora hadn't already been leaning against the wall, she would have collapsed. Catra glances up again, her expression soft as she takes in Adora's astonishment. It only takes her a moment more, and then she is shoving her phone back inside her jacket.

"Unblocked on socials, too. Don't you dare tag me in anything, I don't need your rabid fans knowing I exist," Catra tells her, dismissive and casual. Adora's entire concept of reality is coming apart at the seams.

"Does this mean–" she starts, stops. She does not know how that sentence would finish. *Does this mean we are taking again? Does this mean you'll be mean to me? Does this mean I can stop going to every Eighteenth pretending to be there just to spot Catra?*

Catra looks at her, searching. Her brows are drawn together, her lower lip bitten between her teeth. Carefully, she pushes off the opposite wall and approaches Adora. Adora holds deadly still, letting Catra come as close as she is comfortable with.

Catra's hand comes up to rest on the wall beside Adora's head as she slowly drapes herself across Adora's chest, dropping her head to Adora's shoulder before Adora can panic that she is leaning in to kiss her. Adora lets out the breath she was holding and reaches up with shaking hands, wrapping them around Catra's waist carefully. She does not risk drawing her closer, settling for turning her head to tuck her nose into Catra's hair.

"I means I'm willing to see. Friends first, yeah?" Catra tells her, voice soft and muffled. Adora realizes Catra is hiding her face, but she is fine with that. She is fine with a lot, actually, because she has not felt this good in *years*. If Catra needs to hide her face to force herself to say it, she can hide. Adora will build her a fucking fort out of what she can find on set if it means they can talk.

"I can do that. Whatever you're comfortable with," Adora tells her, wanting to ask about *first* but willing to let it lie for now because the idea of having Catra back at all just makes her so *happy*. For a few moments, Adora is content to just hold Catra against her, feeling her soft hair tickle her nose and the steady rise and fall of her breathing, rumbling just a touch.

This moment is amazing, but Adora is even happier with the knowledge that this singular moment is not all she gets. Catra stirs against her, not pulling away, but raising her head from her shoulder. Adora startles back, but the space between their faces is still hardly enough to measure.

"Adora, you are a terrible actress," Catra says, almost like she expects Adora to argue. Adora has no idea where this is going now, but she nods anyway. They are close enough she half-expects her nose to brush against Catra as she does so.

She cringes internally at the thought of Catra, who is going to be at the fucking *Oscars* this year for her latest film, watching her fumbling attempts at making it through their past music videos. Catra has one hand at the collar of Adora's shirt, Adora realizes suddenly, and her brain stutters when the hand flits over her skin as Catra toys with it.

"See, this is why we needed to talk," Catra adds, rolling her eyes as she pointedly looks down at the single point of contact that is making Adora *lose her mind*. Adora knows she is flushed, but she also feels a bit indignant.

"This is why? My acting skills?" Adora asks, a bit incredulous. That actually earns her a laugh from Catra. She leans back just a bit, but she makes no effort to leave Adora's arms. Catra does not drop her collar. It would probably be better for Adora's ability to hold conversation if she did, but she is so grateful that she doesn't.

"There were multiple reasons," Catra tells her, her eyes alight with amusement. "But, like I said, you are a terrible actress," she continues. Adora just nods again, forcing her breathing steady as Catra flattens her hand across her collarbones over the fabric of her cotton shirt. The heat of her hand feels like it is radiating from Adora's skin into her heart.

"So don't act, Adora. For today, let's just be us again, and maybe if that does not feel too awkward, then we will know?" Catra tells her, starting confident, and then trailing off into a question, biting her lip as she looks up at her. Adora *stares*. This is the furthest thing from how she imagined this conversation going. Not that she is complaining, but she feels like she is twelve steps behind, playing catch up.

"You're okay with that?" Adora asks, brows drawing together as she searches Catra's face. Catra flushes, her tail lashing a little behind her, but she does not back down.

"Maybe I missed you, too," she whispers, eyes locked together. It is not a love confession, not the way Adora's songs have been, but it is

in the way Catra is capable of saying it. Adora draws a shuddering breath and gives a single nod of agreement. Catra lifts her hand from Adora's collar to carefully cup her cheek, her touch gentle like Adora is made of glass. Her gaze is soft, but tinged with sadness.

"We're going to have to be comfortable with each other if we are going to make it through today," Catra tells her. Adora nods. Yes, absolutely. She has never felt this awkward around Catra before. "We have some time left. Let's just spend it getting used to each other again, okay? I had two weeks to prepare for today, but you are going to need all the help you can get," she teases, the way she finishes a clear misdirect for her opening emotion. Clear to Adora, anyway, with sixteen years of Catra expertise under her belt.

"Are you suggesting we use our remaining time to cuddle?" Adora teases back, tightening her arms just a little around Catra's waist, cautious despite Catra's offer. Catra rolls her eyes, but she leans in closer again.

"Even with acting out of the equation, you are going to need to be used to touching me again if we are going to get through this with anything usable," Catra tells her, resting her head on Adora's shoulder again. Experimentally, Adora raises one hand to scratch the spot behind Catra's ear that she always loved. A purr springs forth between them immediately. Catra's ears twitch as she sighs with contentment and leans into the touch.

"I don't want to get used to this again and lose it," Adora whispers, voice soft. If Catra was still looking at her, she wouldn't be able to admit it, but she needs to say it. She needs to take this one small step to protect her heart before she gives in to Catra again. Catra presses just a bit closer, tightening her grip on Adora.

"It's- complicated, okay? But Adora, I missed you so fucking much. And now that I know how you felt about me, I'm not leaving again. There is no one who knows me like you do. There never could be," Catra tells her, voice thick with emotion. Adora takes a shaking

breath, dropping her hand from behind Catra's ear to place it on the back of her neck and squeeze lightly .

Catra takes the hint, raising her head and meeting her eyes. The raw vulnerability in her eyes almost knocks Adora over. Catra is the best actress she has ever met. If she wanted to hide how she was feeling right now, she could do so easily. She really is letting her back in.

"Are you sure you're comfortable with this? Today?" Adora asks, eyes searching. Some of the emotion clears and Catra sends her an annoyed look, but the smile on her lips is fond.

"I wouldn't have taken the job if I wasn't. Now , do you want to take our last few minutes together to cuddle, or do you want to go out and face your entourage?" Catra asks. It is not even a *question* and Catra knows it. Adora pulls Catra tight against her as the other woman laughs, unsurprised.

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Adora half expects to step out of the trailer to find her entire group with their ears pressed against the door. When she emerges, turning around and offering her hand to Catra to guide her as she descends the trailer steps, she is impressed by their restraint. Adora has always been tightlipped about her past and personal life - it is the only way she feels she can keep it out of the press - and Catra has suddenly appeared like an open door to it.

Even back when they were dating Rebellion did not know who her partner was, although that was initially due to Adora not being out professionally. Her bandmates are standing just outside of earshot of the trailer, huddled in a loose half-circle opened in the direction of the trailer so they can all keep an eye out for the door opening. Even from here Adora can tell they are whispering to each other furiously.

Adora sees several phones tuck away, no doubt googling Catra frantically, as they are spotted. The heads huddled together come up, everyone plastering on faux-innocent smiles. Well, everyone but Mermista, who continues to look blank and aloof despite her phone definitely having been part of the circle. Frosta opts to scowl, instead, eyes focusing on Catra as she drapes herself over Adora's arm.

"Well? Going to introduce me to your friends?" Catra asks, smirking, all confidence in the light of day. Like Adora said – she could have Oscars.

"Promise not to bully them. You could tear them apart in minutes," Adora tells her, even as she leads Catra over to where the group is gathered.

"Present that!" Frosta shouts over the gap between them, apparently enough distance crossed for their conversation to be overheard. Catra just purrs in amusement as she scans her calculating gaze over the group.

"Everybody, this is Catra. Catra, this is Rebellion," Adora introduces with a sweeping gesture. Mermista narrows her eyes at where Catra is molded around Adora's bicep.

"Your ex. Who left you two years ago," Mermista corrects. Adora winces, raising her free hand to rub at the back of her neck.

"My ex. who Bow hired," she defends. It is a low blow redirecting attention to Bow like that, but Adora *really* does not want a fight to break out between Catra and the group. Catra's grip on her arm tightens, tail flicking high to tap her on the small of her back. It is silent praise for the misdirect, a code dating back to their days sneaking around behind Shadow's back in the home. Adora feels her breath come a bit quicker at the *familiarity* of it all.

Bow, meanwhile, looks like he wants to die on the spot.

"I'm *sorry*. It isn't easy to find an actress on short notice who fits your specs, okay? If I had known, I never would have done it," Bow stammers. Catra rolls her eyes, breath rumbling slightly with amusement at Bow's discomfort.

"*I* knew, and if it was going to be a problem, I would not have taken the job," Catra placates, surprising Adora. Adora looks down at her, but Catra does not meet her gaze. Her ears twitch back – *embarrassment* – and Adora can't help but wonder why she is comforting people she has claimed hatred for since they started "working Adora into the ground." Maybe they have both come far enough to admit that Adora did that to herself.

"So, what, you two are just fine with acting like you are on a date all afternoon? Adora, do you know what an ex is?" Frosta asks, raising an eyebrow and crossing her arms. That is rich coming from Frosta, considering she has never even been on one, but Adora lets it slide.

"We're friends now," Adora tries, desperately glancing at Catra for help. Catra gives her an obvious *you're on your own* look, but she makes no effort to refute Adora's point. Adora lets out a sigh. "Can you guys just not make this any harder than it is already going to be?" The entire group levels her with a look that clearly says *no*. Well, the entire group minus Bow, who is still looking at Adora with so much remorse she is starting to feel bad.

"Don't worry, it's going to be the best shoot of Adora's career," Catra assures them, wrapping her arm around Adora's waist and pulling her closer. Adora manages to successfully stamp down her blush this time - she thinks.

"Really?" Perfuma asks, voice far too hopeful. She wants this weird, not-conflict to be over already, Adora can tell. Adora meets Catra's gaze to find her looking up at her with a smile that is all teeth and fangs. Nothing about it says *conflict resolution*.

"She doesn't have to act," Catra supplies. Adora groans, but she makes no effort to pull away from Catra as every one of her

bandmates focuses in on her with laser-like intensity.

"Hang me out to dry , why don't you?" Adora asks. Catra laughs in response. Adora's chest bursts with warmth.

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It is, it turns out, the best shoot of Adora's miserable acting career. Despite the way her bandmates hover anxiously around her between every shot thanks to Catra's announcement – Adora is still unclear if she was outing Adora as still in love with her, because everybody *knows that* already, or if she was telling Adora this *is* a date – Adora has fun.

She does not have to worry about acting, just doing her best to follow the directions that Bow gives them. They spend most of the day on their fake date. Bow is nervous to direct them to even touch each other at first, but Catra has no such qualms at taking his directions and running with it until she has Adora giving her a piggyback ride down the pier. The song echoes in the air around them as Angella calls after them to be careful, the worry in her voice almost drowned out by Catra's laughter.

It should be weird, laughing with Catra again like this, especially with all the cameras, people, and calls of *cut* ringing out around them. Every time Adora feels the reality of the situation start to creep in on her, Catra sees the anxiety clouding her eyes. She takes Adora's chin in her hand and tilts her face down to meet Catra's gaze.

"Focus on me. Focus on us. It's just you and me," Catra tells her , despite the numerous voices in the background threatening to disprove her. It still works. Adora is so used to getting lost in Catra's eyes, her voice, her *self* , that it is startlingly easy to let herself slip back under her spell.

She never left it to begin with.

The final shot of the music video is a timed one, supposed to take place at the end of the boardwalk during sunset. It is a tricky shot, one they will only have enough light to try a few times. Adora has very specific stipulations in her contract around what she will do for promos. One of the clauses is that Adora will never kiss anyone or act suggestively for a shoot.

It was a basic rule to her , respecting her and Catra's relationship, and it added protection in case BME went back on Angella's word and made her pretend to be straight. The final shot of the music video is written around that rule. She and Catra are supposed to walk to the end of the boardwalk, look out to the ocean for a moment while they steal glances at each other, and then turn and lean in as if to kiss each other. It is being shot on a drone so the camera can rise out of frame and into the sunset before they get too close.

Bow is extremely flustered as they set up the final shot. Despite having gotten more comfortable directing Adora to be affectionate with her handsy ex-Catra is doing it to keep her in the moment and they both know it - the unspoken line they are crossing with this shot clearly puts him on edge. After an entire day of being in almost constant contact with Catra, Adora is less worried about it now than she had been when she thought it would be with a stranger this morning.

She lays a hand on Bow's shoulder and sends him a reassuring look before walking out to meet Catra at their starting cue. They only end up taking the shot once. They walk hand in hand, Adora finding it easy to ignore the drone hovering before them while focusing in on Catra. She knows she is supposed to look away when they reach the end of the walk, but she *can't* , so drawn in watching Catra's eyes dance in the sunset.

Catra looks towards her shyly to steal her glance and finds herself suddenly meeting Adora's eyes. She seems to be instantly trapped by Adora's gaze, her own eyes widening as she turns her body

towards her unconsciously. They draw together like magnets, Adora's hand coming up to cup Catra's cheek without her telling it to. They are facing each other now, the look in Catra's eyes soft, anxious, and *excited*.

They lean in without any need for words or creative instruction, Adora's eyes flicking down to Catra's lips briefly. The sound of the drone's engines picks up as it lifts up to capture the sunset shot, but it does not move fast enough to miss Adora as she, completely dismissive of the world around them, seals their lips together in a real kiss, Catra leaning into her happily.

Somewhere in the distance, someone wolf whistles. Mermista, probably. When they pull apart, Adora stares down at Catra, her blush blazing, and giggles, a little flustered and completely awkward. Catra just rolls her eyes, but her ears are twitched back and her blush is furious. She does not pull away from where Adora's arms have come up around her.

They stay there, just standing in each other's air, for a long moment before Bow calls out to them and breaks the spell. They review the shot when they walk back up the boardwalk. No one says anything as they watch it, the camera rising past their lips just a second before they connect, offering the illusion that they could have not kissed. From the angle, everybody can tell they did.

The open affection, the raw surprise of being caught looking and taking the chance – it is perfect. Bow calls wrap on the shoot, and Adora offers to walk Catra out to her car to avoid the burning stares from her bandmates.

Chapter End Notes

> Like in my other fics, Shadow Weaver's legal name is first name Shadow, last name Weaver. Bite me. Also, it is in the tags, but everybody is the same species they are in the show.

The Diner (Date)

Chapter Summary

> It is your fault because apparently your biceps are like catnip to horny lesbians. Do you read your Twitter mentions, Adora? I read some of the replies from your vague tweets about the shoot. They were perverted even by my standards," Catra tells her. She sounds far too amused at the shitshow that is Adora's daily life.

Chapter Notes

> EDIT April 19th, 2021: I'm doing an edit of this fic currently, so I've updated the way I did the social tweets to hopefully be more screen-reader friendly. As long as the screen reader has an easy shortcut for skipping a line when the repeated @ and time stamps come up, it should work a bit better. That was always a problem before regardless, so hopefully I've at least dealt with the others.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The diner is small, but well-lit. It smells like grease in the best kind of way, the heavy scents of bacon, syrup, eggs, and other breakfast foods hanging in the air. It is the kind of place that looks like it has belonged to the same family for generations and they have kept it in the same immaculate condition their grandfather did. Knowing LA, it is probably a recreation that has only been open for a few months.

"I learned about this place from my lead for *Portal Quest*. He never had any problems with his dates here making their way to the public," Catra tells Adora when she slides into the booth seat across from her. Adora got here a full thirty minutes before they agreed to meet, exceedingly eager, but Catra was early too, even if only by ten minutes, so it seems they may both be excited. "Plus, their breakfast waffle sandwiches are to die for," Catra adds.

It is the first time they have seen each other face-to-face since the music video shoot a week ago. They have been texting around Catra's busy shoot schedule, but Adora has been desperate to actually see Catra again. It took her a few days to work up the courage to ask if she could see her, but Catra immediately returned that she had Saturday off from filming her current film.

They order their food, bickering over the menu like they used to when they were teenagers, spending the last few cents they had from their summer jobs on one of their rare, secret dates. It feels natural to fall into their old routine again, Adora ordering Catra's favourite tea for her when the waiter comes by without thinking. She pretends she not to notice the way it makes Catra gaze openly at her.

"So, the music video teaser went up today ," Adora says, conversationally, as she fidgets with her napkin ring. Catra doesnt buy her *casual* act for even a second.

"They used the kiss, didnt they?" Catra says, raising an eyebrow at her. Adora flushes and nods. Catra wrinkles her nose a little. "I'm going to bury my twitter mentions now, thanks. I bet half your fans want to kill me and the other half want to *be* me," Catra tells her . Adora pouts a little in response.

"Hey , you kissed me too. I don't see how this is my fault," Adora defends, gesturing a bit wildly. Catra sends a skittering glance out to the rest of the diner and Adora realizes her volume has risen. She winces, slumping down in her seat a bit. They are not alone, and the last thing they need to do is draw attention to themselves. Adora has her hair down in an effort to remain more anonymous than her signature ponytail allows for, but if people start *looking,* she knows she is likely screwed.

"It is your fault because apparently your biceps are like catnip to horny lesbians. Do you read your T witter mentions, Adora? I read some of the replies from your vague tweets about the shoot. They were *pretty,* even by my standards," Catra tells her . She sounds

far too amused at the shitshow that is Adora's daily life. Adora is aware of what her mentions are like, that is why she *avoids* them.

She wants to defend herself, because she really has done *nothing* to attract this kind of attention aside from being out, but their waiter returns with their food and the conversation pulls to a halt. Catra was right, the waffle sandwich is incredible. They get a few minutes to just enjoy the grease and each other's company, idly chatting back and forth, before Catra asks her about it.

"So how are things with the group?" she asks, casually, raising an eyebrow as she takes a bite. She is much better at feigning nonchalance than Adora, but Adora knows this subject could never be a *meaningless conversation* between them.

"In general, or after Sunday?" Adora returns. Catra smiles, Adora's defensive snark apparently bringing her joy, but then she pauses, seeming to actually considering it.

"Both, I guess? Clearly, they still didn't know a lot about me, but what they think about you stepping back is also important," Catra says. The second half she says almost cautiously, like she is expecting Adora to correct her - like she thinks that now that Adora has Catra talking to her, she is going to go back on her word.

"They've been blowing up the group chat constantly about why I never told them my ex was *you*, but in general they get why I keep stuff private. They still know about the same stuff they did when we were dating, plus what came out in the songs on *Heatstings*. We grew up together, we had it rough, and we broke up over the stress of the debut," Adora tells her, rubbing the back of her neck. Catra absorbs the information silently, eyes focused on the table and nodding along.

"Frght-Zone knows about the same stuff, they just don't know it is *you* and not some random singer. Except for Lonnie and Scorpia, of course, but they haven't told anybody. Scorpia didn't even tell Perfuma, you know?" Catra replies. Catra might not have any

professional ties to Frght-Z but she is pretty close friends with all their members. She spends most of her time with them when she is not filming a movie.

Adora blinks, a bit surprised, because Scorpia is so notoriously bad at keeping secrets she leaked their last single on accident, but it eases her a bit to know Catra had someone she could talk to about it all. Adora had friends, best friends even, but no one who knew much of anything about her before they turned eighteen and hopped a Greyhound to LA. Scorpia and Lonnie were only a few months behind them.

"Scorpia is the reason Bow hired me, apparently . He was complaining to Perfuma about finding an actress that fit your specifications on short notice and Perfuma mentioned that her girlfriend had a friend who might fit the requirements," Catra adds on, raising an eyebrow at her. Adora does her best to sink through the floor. She was hoping to talk about this exactly *never* . Catra's smile is taunting.

"What are your *specifications* , Adora?" she asks, far too amused by Adora's discomfort. Adora glares at her, but she sighs and sits up. Carefully, she fixes her gaze on her half-eaten sandwich before replying so she doesn't have to watch Catra' s reaction in real time.

"Remember when you tried to give me acting advice for my first shoot and you told me that realistic acting comes from your past and stuff? So when you need to cry , you think about something that hurt you?" Adora asks, chancing a peek at Catra. She narrows her eyes at Adora, but she nods. Adora fixes her gaze on her brunch again.

"Most of our music videos are choreo and performance, so it doesn't usually matter, but whenever we need to shoot a love song, I take out my contacts and have them hire an actress who kind of looks like you. It makes it easier to try to pull up that emotion if I can pretend it is you there. I just told them I have a type," she admits, cringing a little. After a moment of silence from Catra, Adora risks looking up.

Catra looks flustered, her ears and tail twitching as her cheeks colour. Adora hunches down in her seat a little again, but at least Catra does not look *annoyed*. She didn't want Catra to think she was trying to replace her, or that any of those random girls could even hold a candle to her. Luckily, Catra seems torn between amused and flattered.

"So they accidentally hired me while looking for an actress that fit the description you gave them *of me*?" she asks, lip curling, apparently having decided on mocking Adora for this mercilessly. Adora throws her hands up in the air, but she is smiling a little from her relief.

"I'm a bad actress!" she defends, whining just a little. Catra smirks, reaching across the table to pat Adora's cheek. It would be condescending if the spark of contact did not send a jolt of excitement running through her. *Okay*, it is still condescending, but Adora finds herself leaning into the touch just a little even as she glares at Catra.

"It's okay, princess. You have plenty of other talents I enjoy," Catra practically coos. Adora bats her hand away, glaring at her, but a smile is still twitching at the corner of her mouth.

"*Anyway*," she redirects, trying to move on from the omission, "the group has been really supportive about it. Everyone saw how bad I crashed and burned leading up to *Heartstrings*. I was talking with Angella about how I might not need to really be in the next express tour. Our fanbase is big enough now that they are promoting the new single themselves, so she thinks I can get away with doing social posts and just a few interviews with the rest of the group," Adora explains.

Catra looks almost stricken, swallowing thickly. Press tours are such a touchy subject for Adora – for *them*. Cutting them down would change things completely. All three of Adora's hospitalizations have been during tours, though if it weren't for how she wore herself down in preparation for the initial release, she never would have ended up in that position.

"That's- really good, Adora," Catra manages. Adora looks up at her with a small smile, maybe a touch too hopeful, but it is honest. Catra's gaze darts away before she meets her eyes again. "You're really doing this, huh?" she asks, apparently at a loss for words. Adora shrugs.

"I put my career ahead of us, before. You are my priority this time. I still can't say I completely regret it – having built our fanbase up is what's giving me the freedom to step back like this – but I want to do things right this time," Adora admits. She sees Catra's ears drop a little, clearly trying to hold back disappointment. Taking a chance, Adora reaches across the table and takes Catra's hand. Catra allows it, though her expression doesn't change.

"Catra, this was never about fame, or success, or anything like that. I just loved music and wanted us to be able to support ourselves. When I lost you – I lost myself, in a lot of ways. I learned to stand on my own, but I don't *want* to. I want you in my life again," she confesses in a low whisper, cognizant of the fact that they are technically in public, even if they're largely alone in the sparsely populated diner.

She watches Catra's eyes cloud and then miraculously clear. She watches the way her tail quivers for a moment, fingers trembling and claws flexing, before her body stills and relaxes. Catra takes her emotions and shoves them back down, hiding them behind a thin smile. Normally Adora hates when Catra does that with her, but she knows they are in front of strangers.

"Okay. You were always my top priority, Adora. You still will be. I get busy whenever I'm shooting a movie, but I have plenty of downtime between shoots to make up for it. I usually get a day or two off of shooting a week. We can make it work," Catra promises her. Adora feels the grip of fear on her heart loosen. She squeezes Catra's hand beneath hers and slowly releases it, leaning back in her seat.

For a few moments, they eat in silence, both of them processing. Adora knows that despite her skills, it is difficult for Catra to hide

when she is upset, so she needs the time to slowly deconstruct the emotion before they can really return to normal conversation, especially about anything light-hearted. They really should turn to something light-hearted.

They are still in public, after all. It is a miracle they have not been spotted yet. Almost on cue with the thought, Catra hunches down in her seat.

"The manager is texting an awful lot," she mutters into the remainder of her food, eyes glancing over Adora's shoulder to look into the kitchens. Adora stoically does not turn around. She knows what Catra is implying – she could tell even without the anxious flick of her tail against the booth next to her.

Adora has gone through the trial by fire of a meteoric rise to fame – she is used to this kind of thing by now. Catra was always the more cautious of them, the one with more reason to fear Shadow catching them as kids. Adora does not blame her for her paranoia.

"If we're going to start seeing each other again, we will get spotted together eventually," Adora points out, trying to keep her voice casual, but she is *nervous*. They always feared their relationship being public before, and she may love the opportunities Rebellion's fans have given them, but the attention they get can be absolutely overwhelming. Catra is a known face, but the fandom for a young film actress is nothing like the rabid idol fans that have sprung up around Rebellion.

"I know. It was always inevitable, but I would like us to get to the point where we know who we are without the public pressure, first," Catra sighs, picking at her plate a little dejectedly. The kiss flashes before Adora's eyes. She bites her lip, abandoning her fork and reaching across the table to hold Catra's free hand again. Catra smiles a little looking down at their hands.

"Okay, maybe we know," she agrees, and just like that, it goes from brunch to a *date*.

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STREAMFIND @ofnthenk • Saturday

OMG Adora Grayskull is at my brother’s diner rn!! he says it looks like she is on a date

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STREAMFIND @ofnthenk • Friday
@ofnthenk

guys the lesbian may finally be over her heartbreak im sweating. he says theyre holding hands im so happy for her! we're really getting more love songs soon!

STREAMFIND @ofnthenk • Friday
@ofnthenk

ugh stop replying just to accuse me of making it up. YES im in class right now but my brothers texting me cuz he knows i love her. ill post screenshots when i can edit them later . i dont want you guys tracking down where my brother works

---

STREAMFIND @ofnthenk • Friday
@ofnthenk

also like leave their date alone if u were tru fans you would want her to be happy!the new single is a love song and i BET its about this girl!i dont wanna be the one to ruin it for them

---

STREAMFD *@f ntheink • f • Eg to @f ntheink*

HOLD ON my brother says he thinks he recognizes the date stand by lesbians we're googling

---

STREAMFD *@f ntheink • f • Eg to @f ntheink*

ASUFHUSLRGSRGSRGLSD NO W AY

STREAMFD *@f ntheink • f • Eg to @f ntheink*

OK NOT SA NG WHO SHE S BUT HIS S SOME STORY BOOKSHIT . LK NOW I NOW HOW HEY MET AND EVER FING AND NOW HERE ON A D E TOGETHER HIS S T OO MUCH

STREAMFD *@f ntheink • f • Eg to @f ntheink*

i cant say who she is stop asking!she isnt out from what i can tell. im nosy not a fucking monster. shes a celeb too thats all i can say

---

STREAMFD *@f ntheink • f • Eg to @f ntheink*

sorry to bail i had to start actually paying attention. big bro says they tipped well and then he wouldnt tell me more lmao. i think they bribed him but you know what thats fair chase those tips

---

STREAMFIND *@ntheink • 1d • Edited to @ntheink*

ok here are the screenshots. i blocked out the identifying info for the date & y'all just have to deal with it. im not fucking outing somebody and im not a gossip account im just a stan ok

--

Adora tries not to glare at her laptop as she scrolls through the tweets and articles Angella had their social team send over to her. She texted Adora as soon as it happened, but Adora had her phone turned off so she could enjoy her day trip into LA proper . Catra took her to the backlot of her last film, pointing out the trailer she rescued her stray cat out from under, and then she took Adora on a tour of the stage she is currently filming in.

It was nice just getting to spend time holding hands and not having to worry about the world outside of the studio gates. Now, a day later and back in her own apartment, she has to finally face the music. Sighing, she picks up her phone and selects Catra's contact.

"I'm on set, so don't say anything you don't want the world to know , babe. I have time, though," Catra greets her . She sounds amused, but Adora cringes a little.

"So you saw , then," she clarifies. She can practically hear Catra rolling her eyes. Well, okay, *no* she can't, but she knows Catra well enough to know that is what she is doing right now.

"Like I said, getting spotted was inevitable with your fanbase. We're just lucky the waiter kept his mouth shut about us taking the same car away. Somehow I don't think the internet would believe that the rest of the day was an innocent tour," Catra reasons. Adora huffs. Unfortunately, Catra is probably right.

"I haven't even gotten to kiss you, they can't start on us having *sex*," Adora complains, well aware she is whining, but she really isn't used to this. The entire time she has been an idol, there have been rumours about her dating pretty much any girl she looks at, but she has never had them be *true* before.

"Princess, last Sunday?" Catra reminds her. Adora feels herself flush. Catra called her that for the first time in nearly two years yesterday, but Adora missed it while they were apart, and it still sends a thrill of excitement through her to hear it again.

"There were cameras. It doesn't count. Take me home to meet Melog like you promised and we can fix that," Adora tells her, maybe a bit too bold, but Catra's teasing has always had an effect on her. Catra laughs on the other end of the line as Adora hears the stage door warning bell begin to ring out. Catra waits for things to quiet down again before responding.

"Buy me dinner next time and I'll consider it. Actually, better yet, aren't you going to be in New York this weekend?" Catra responds. Adora pauses, running through her mental schedule for the single release.

"Yeah, doing three interviews. You want to visit an old haunt? Maybe dinner in Brooklyn? I can see who Angella can bribe so we don't have a repeat of yesterday," Adora tells her. Catra hums in satisfaction.

"I have Saturday and Sunday off. I can fly out to meet you after the first show. Find us somewhere new – the city is enough for me without old memories. And get a private hotel, yeah? I want to have

time with you without having to worry about being overheard or anything,” Catra tells her .

“I can do that! I will do that. Right now , in fact,” Adora promises her . She hears Catra laughing lightly on the other end of the line.

“Alright, princess, I trust you will take care of us. I have to get back to set now. I'll call you when I get home tonight,” Catra promises her . Adora picked up the phone filled with anxiety , but now she feels as light as she did yesterday, blissfully ignorant of getting caught and totally absorbed in being with Catra again.

--

CGI'D *IMITATION* STAR CATRA CYRA BEGINS TO GLOW

Leaks from the *You Will Be Told* set hint the actress is in a secret relationship with another female celebrity.

Article by Bubble Bonbon for MEOWdeen

Catra Cyra is a rising star. After some minor roles, she entered the film scene explosively with a supporting role in the summer blockbuster *Portal* that propelled her to the supporting role in the three-time Oscar-nominated film *Initiation* . One of those Oscars could have Catra's name on it for Best Supporting Actress come award season. The young starlet is already shooting her next film as the main actress, but there is a secret *You Will Be Told* from the new film's set.

According to multiple sources working on the production lot, Catra brought a mysterious woman to visit the set this weekend during a break in filming. She has never brought anyone on set before, according to the same sources. Yesterday, Catra took a phone call

while on set that had some interesting revelations about who the woman could be.

"She is dating another female star . The other voice was clearly a woman. Catra called her '*princess*' and '*babe*'," our anonymous source on the set says. Over the course of the phone call, Catra let slip that her new beau's fans caught them out on a date together and that they went home together afterwards. She also planned a follow-up date, one requiring a private hotel afterwards. Whoever she is seeing is certainly getting some of her famous tail!

Catra Cyra is not publicly out, though she is known to associate with the idol group Fright-Zan all-lesbian fronted group. There have been rumours in the past that she was dating the leader, Scorpia. Scorpia is currently in a public relationship with fellow idol Perfuma, a member of the band Rebellion. With her long-time focus off the market, it seems Catra has found a new object for her affections.

Catra has never played a film role requiring more than brief romantic tension between her and her male leads, and perhaps now we know why. She has recently starred as the lesbian love interest in Rebellion's latest music video for their new single *Bad* . The music video releases this Friday, but a trailer released over the weekend shows her kissing Rebellion's leader Adora Grayskull.

Adora Grayskull has been an out lesbian ever since Rebellion's first album release, and thus far has only acted alongside other LGBT actresses in her music videos. Even without Catra's telling conversation, this latest role should be turning some women's heads in her direction.

--

Catra @catra • Monday

f you thought Iwas straight then that’ s on you

○ ↻ ♥

@spacedragon • Replying to @catra

wait 4 real marry me then

@sapphicdate • Replying to @catra

Fucking tell them sister!

@madmoth • Replying to @catra

What’s this in reference to can somebody link me?

@of nthenight • Replying to @catra

interesting.

Chapter End Notes

Iknow twitter timestamps dont look exactly like this, but Ididnt want to nail myself down to dates. Ive never included social posts in a fic before, so Ihope Idid it okay because there’ s gonna be more of that going forward.

Outed (as in love)

Chapter Summary


CATRA DOESN'T SEE HOW SHE SEES ADORA TODAY


ADORA WHY DON'T YOU TELL US YOU WERE A HOE

Chapter Notes

So this AU was pretty spontaneous and I didn't have much planned/outlined for it past chapter 5, but I think I finally have a rough outline and it will probably be 10 chapters. I've already added two to my initial "plan" so I can't guarantee anything lol I'm just having fun here.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Good job getting caught, dumbass," is Mermista's greeting when Adora walks into the dance studio on Monday. Adora groans, tossing her gym bag against the wall and shooting her an annoyed look.

"We're not used to this, okay? Neither of us had a fanbase when we broke up," Adora defends, walking to the center of the room to join the rest of the group in their warmup. She knows Mermista is only teasing – she knows she is just happy it is not *her* for once. "At least *we* didn't set anything on fire," Adora points out, elbowing Mermista with a smirk. The way Mermista flushes and quickly turns away with a muttered "whatever" only fuels her smugness.

"How are you this bad at sneaking around but you managed to hide that Catra was Heartstrings for two years?" Frosta asks, gaze just a shade below accusing. Adora feels a pang in her stomach. If Frosta is feeling betrayed when she was not even part of the group then, Adora can only imagine how the rest of her friends are feeling. She

abandons her stretch, flopping back against the studio floor with a sigh.

"We decided when I got scouted we would keep our relationship private, okay? I wasn't going to break that trust just because she had left. She did it for my own good, anyway. Even if it took awhile," Adora tells them, sending a glare to each member of the group in turn. Most of them look unimpressed, but no one challenges her decision.

"Does Frght-Zone know?" Perfuma asks, quietly. She looks apologetic to be continuing the questioning, but Adora gets it. She wants to know if she can talk with her girlfriend about it. The fact she has not so far is really a testament to what a good friend Perfuma is. Adora feels a spark of warmth in her chest, smiling for the first time since she got off the phone with Catra that morning. She returns to her warmup exercises.

"Most of them, no. I think Catra is going to tell them now that we are back together, but they didn't know before you. Except Scorpia and Lonnie, obviously, but we grew up together," Adora explains. Most of the group nods, seeming to accept that and willing to drop the subject. Perfuma looks mildly delighted, unspoken permission granted to stop keeping a secret from her girlfriend. Glimmer, however, still has a sour twist to her mouth. Adora sighs as she switches positions.

"It's not like I told them stuff that I kept from you. We went on a double date with them in high school once, okay? They have known since before we even thought about moving to LA. They used to help us sneak around the hom- homophobes and stuff," Adora explains, words pausing awkwardly midsentence. She bites her lip at her near-admission. Luckily, the group seems to read it as *bad enemies* – which isn't wrong either – and they drop it. Glimmer shoots her an apologetic look.

"I know it has to be hard to be publicly out. I don't really have a place to judge, I'm sorry," Glimmer apologizes with a shrug, turning away.

Adora just nods, absorbing the apology if it means this line of questioning is over. Glimmer is not in the closet, but there is a big difference between not hiding her attractions and publicly saying she is bi. There is a pause before Glimmer looks back at her with a smirk.

"I can't believe you listened to me rant about how hot she was in *that* location and didn't say anything. You let me *twist tweet* about your ex, Adora," Glimmer complains, half-joking and half-embarrassed. Adora can't help but laugh.

"What can I say? You were right," Adora shrugs. "Now, if you're done grilling me, let's get started on the choreo, yeah? There is a lot less leeway for a live performance than a music video. We need to have this on lock by Saturday," Adora reminds, directing the group into their starting positions.

--

Catra shared a location with you

I know it's late but can you just come over and exist near me

I'm at the studio but I was about to leave

I can get a helicopter so I can skip the evening traffic

Do you take a helicopter to go miles?

Actually nvm I just mapped it and your studio is three hours away rn

How do you even work that far out?

Ilive twenty minutes from the studio. Normally it' s not an issue

Im not even mad about it the article was just fucking disgusting

And now my agent is yelling at me and people are being weird on set

Ugh Igotta go Im up. Ill be home by the time you get there anyway

--

Catra snatches a hand out and grabs Adora by the front of her shirt, yanking her inside the apartment the moment Catra opens her door. She eyes Adora almost suspiciously.

"Subtle," she comments dryly , eyeing Adora's appearance. Adora feels herself flush. She is still in her leggings and cropped shirt from practice, her signature ponytail up. f she tried to take it out after practice, it would be held in place with the dried sweat. She didnt want to delay by going back to her apartment when the helicopter was ready to leave from the studio roof.

"t' s dark out," she defends, cautiously . The night is the only real protection she has against getting recognized. In her current outfit, her infamous backpiece is on full display, the sword recognizable even with the handle hidden beneath her top. Still, the whole reason she is here is because of them getting caught before. She would have been more careful if she hadnt been so worried about making sure Catra was okay.

Catra sighs, but she just turns around and waves Adora deeper inside the apartment. Adora follows, eyeing how bare the tiny space is as Catra takes her past the cramped living room and into the

bedroom. The only furniture inside is a bed and a cat tower with a cat lounging on it. Catra notices the way Adora's eyes flit around the space, so small and yet so bare. She rolls her eyes, walking over to the cat tower and reaching out for Melog, who jumps into her arms happily.

"Having stuff is inconvenient when I only live in a place for two or three months at a time. I'd rather not have much and live in a private apartment than deal with living out of a hotel with the rest of the crew," Catra explains, walking back to Adora with Melog cradled against her chest. She looks up to Adora with wide eyes, almost cautious as she raises him up a little.

"I wasn't judging, just worried. Hey , little guy," Adora greets, reaching out a hand for Melog to sniff. Catra said he is very sweet for a stray cat, but Adora has been scratched enough by *tamed* cats to know to be cautious.

Okay, Catra could never really be considered tamed.

Melog sniffs her hand cautiously for a moment before nudging into her touch. Adora pets his head, scratching behind his ears and earning an instant purr. When she makes eye contact with Catra again, her girlfriend practically has hearts in her eyes watching the exchange. She catches Adora watching her and quickly looks away , her cheeks flushing.

"I told you that he would love you," Catra tells her in a flustered mutter. Adora smirks at her and Catra flicks an ear in faux annoyance, turning away. After a moment, she walks over to the bed and sits on the edge of it, settling Melog in her lap. She looks up to Adora questioningly and Adora follows her without hesitation. She sits beside Catra, sides brushing, and takes a risk on wrapping an arm around her waist.

Catra melts into her side, releasing a shaking breath that Adora can tell she has been holding in all day. It is all the encouragement Adora needs to toe off her shoes and guide Catra to lay back in her arms,

holding her close. She ends up with Catra cuddled against her chest, Melog curled between them and still purring.

"You okay?" she asks, softly. She knows the answer, but she wants to give Catra the opening to talk about it. Catra's breathing is a little unsteady, but her eyes remain clear, even if they are anxious. Her ears and fingers twitch with anxiety, little ticks that show she has been suppressing her emotions for too long to keep holding them down.

"Getting better. I talked with my agent and stuff. They are mad I didn't tell them I had a girlfriend, especially after I told them it's *you*, but I told them the opportunities they have gotten me doesn't make me just trust them with all my secrets. Some people were being weird on set, too. Homophobes or trying *not* to be homophobic, probably," Catra elaborates, scooting just a little closer as she talks.

"I just- needed to see you. To know we were still okay," Catra explains, gaze fixed determinedly on Adora's collar. Adora understands the fear. The second she had read the articles about her, she called Catra, after all. She pauses, taking a risk and leaning forward to press a firm kiss against Catra's forehead, hoping to anchor and assure her. She feels Catra relax in her arms, sending a wave of relief through her.

The purr between them stops as Melog, apparently feeling too crushed now Adora is leaning forward, jumps out from Catra's arms. The purr is quickly replaced by Catra's own as she presses closer, molding their bodies together. Melog resettles somewhere near the foot of the bed if the direction of the vibrations are anything to go by, but Adora is too busy focusing in on Catra to care. Their faces are barely an inch or two apart and Catra's eyes are soft with emotion as she gazes at Adora.

"I missed you," Catra whispers, low and soft. They both know what she really means. Adora swallows, her breathing going a touch unsteady for a moment.

"I missed you too," Adora promises in return. It seems to be the final step that Catra needs. She closes the airgap between them, kissing Adora softly. Adora meets her, gentle and cautious. She thinks Catra needs this, but-

Catra tries to deepen the kiss and Adora pulls back. She sees a flash of panic in Catra's eyes before she manages to make herself look carefully blank, devoid of emotion.

"Hey, I don't do that. Not with me. I never want you to hide with me," Adora tells her, reaching a hand up to gently stroke Catra's cheek. Catra stares at her, still carefully blank, before she draws in a shuddering breath and her eyes uncloud from their blank stare. She looks blatantly *scared*.

"Why'd you stop?" she asks, soft and quiet. It sounds like she expects Adora to say she didn't *want* to keep going.

"You're upset, we only just reconnected... I don't want you to do something you aren't ready for just to get reassurance. I'm here. I'm with you. I'm not leaving," Adora promises her, still gently stroking her cheek. Catra's eyes flutter closed, her breathing unsteady. A small, fond smile is spreading on her face. It makes Adora's chest clench to see happiness on her girlfriend again.

"Okay, princess. You can be a hero if you want to, but I'm *always* ready for kisses. I would have kissed you on Saturday if it wouldn't have given us away," Catra returns. Her voice sounds shaky with relief as she wraps her arms around Adora's back, pulling her closer. She looks up at her questioningly, the cloud of fear and anxiety retreated now. "Kiss me?" she asks.

Adora doesn't need to be asked twice.

--

RBERBE BCH T

Gbes >

Fst baby

Adora where tf are u Ive never gotten in before you

Im driving there right now . Im not late.

Snt sng vicetotek

Bow ♡

Dnt tek and drive! You have thirty minutes still just wait!

Mma

She isnt late by human standards but she is like an hour late by Adora standards

Im using hands-free and stuck in traf fic it's fine.

Snt sng vicetotek

Itold you guys Im trying to take care of myself. That means sleeping in the mornings.

Snt sng vicetotek

Ok ✨

Ibet Catra stayed over

Mia

Adora why didnt you tell us you were a hoe

Catra didnt stay over

Sent using voicetotext

Efran

Everybody stop messaging she will just keep replying! We dont want an accident!

Ihavent moved more than a few inches in sixminutes

Sent using voicetotext

Best baby

Wait where are you with such bad traffic rn?

Glimmer ✨

CATRA DIDNT STAY OVER SHE STAYED TO CATRA S

Mia

ADORA WHY DIDNT YOU TELL US YOU WERE A HOE

Bow ♡

Car accident guys?

Ef an

Well she seems to have stopped replying

Mia

OH NOW YOURE SHY

--

Waking up next to Catra, even still in her dirty gym clothes and with blurry vision as she searches for her glasses, is the only assurance Adora needs that it doesn't matter what the public knows or when, not as long as she gets to have this. She and Catra manage to get in a few kisses before she has to run off to her set, Adora promising to feed Melog for her so they can have a little more time together.

Catra texts Adora the instructions to feed Melog as she makes her way out to her car and wrestles to get the engine to turn over. Adora knows this because of the string of curses Catra sends after the instructions, with the only non-expletive among them the word "HORDAK." Adora would have assumed that Catra had replaced their shitty old car by now, but she doubts Catra bought a new car that is also shitty and carried the name over.

Actually, no, that tracks. Adora can totally picture Catra buying a new car, realizing it is shitty, and then cursing it out as it breaks down and calling it Hordak insultingly. It is so easy to conjure up the image that Adora can't help but smile to herself. As she slowly pets Melog, who

is busily purring into his food, she feels herself bursting with words, but none of them are coherent enough to form into lyrics. She settles on a tweet.

--

Adora Gayskill *@adoragayskill · 2d*

Itried to write a song but it boiled down to love is pretty great. Im really gay you guys

---

Mermista *@mermista · 2d* *Reply to @adoragayskill*

Just dont let it make you late

Glimmer! *@glimmer · 2d* *Reply to @adoragayskill and @mermista*

@mermistary Shhh let the lesbian have this

1meme away fom breakng *@adoraself tbicep · 2d* *Reply to @adoragayskill*

ASDSHF you guys are too much

STREAMFD @fintherink • 1m Reply to @adoragasku

idk i think movies r pretty good too

ITS TRENDS @madorastan • 8m Reply to @fintherink

@fintherink Haha forever alone club am Iright

--

"So, people are tweeting me asking if you're a good kisser ," Catra says in lieu of a greeting when she picks up the phone. Adora had been in the middle of a workout when Catra texted her that she had a private room for a bit between shots. Adora quickly abandoned her routine in favour of talking to Catra. They text in a steady stream, but Catra's shoot is packed with long hours, and if they want to avoid a repeat of Sunday they usually cant call during the day .

Adora groans. The music video has been up for only two hours, but Rebellion's fans are nothing if not unreasonably fast and horny. She blames it on the crowd attracted by their choreo, but she knows it is probably just part of being in the public eye. She has glanced at other musicians' replies and they generally arent much better .

"I know that tone of voice. Y ou replied, didnt you?" Adora responds, glaring indistinctly at the ceiling and wondering how much of an apology she owes Angella. Catra trills happily down the line.

"I told them that someone taught you some moves," she responds, far too smug. Adora feels herself flush, fidgeting where she lays on the mat despite Catra being unable to actually see her.

"Uh," she manages, intelligently. Catra's laugh rings down the line. Adora finds herself staring at the ceiling with wide eyes, cheeks flushed as she drinks in the sound.

"They are shipping us already, by the way. With conspiracy theories that we are actually dating now because of that one fan's tweets. Scorpia is baiting them. She tweeted about me joining the family' or whatever," Catra tells her. She sounds amused. Adora closes her eyes, just letting Catra's voice wash over her, subject matter be damned. "They have always been afraid of being public about being together, but the mention of Scorpia's tweets opens a door in her mind she thought she had closed a long time ago.

"I wish we didn't have to sneak around," Adora sighs. In the distance, she hears the stage door warning bell ringing out, but it is far away and muffled.

"Are you trying to say something, princess?" Catra questions. She still sounds a little amused, but there is a cautious edge to her voice. Adora sighs.

"No, not really. Ideally, we could just go on dates and talk and it would be between the two of us, but it doesn't work like that anymore. I kind of wish I could be open like that – just tweet about you and not have it be weird, but it *is* weird knowing how many people are watching," Adora explains, waving her hand around as she talks. Catra hums thoughtfully.

"I get that. I want to keep this between us as long as we can, but once people know – we spent long enough having to hide already, don't you think? I want to be able to say that you are mine and be proud of it. Besides, the fan edits are cute," Catra tells her, tone turning teasing. Adora feels her chest warm as she indulges the idea before it is quickly replaced with a flash of panic.

"*Please* don't look at those. They get weird," Adora scrambles to tell her.

They *get* weird? Adora, people are already doing edits of your back tattoo with claw marks in it and talking about how wild our sex must be. I found an entire Instagram dedicated to your abs. There's another one about your thighs. There's already a bot account that tweets out '*catdora*' updates. I think it's run by that Tiffany girl who outed us initially. It tweets the same, anyway," Catra informs her, rattling off the list of things she has seen. Despite the way the list makes Adora wince, it only scratches the surface of the fan content Adora knows exists.

"Delete your twitter," Adora decides. *Before it's too late*. Catra has the nerve to laugh at her.

"Are you kidding? I wouldn't miss this for the world. Maybe we *should* come out. If this is what they do for someone who you interacted with *once,* I can hardly imagine what they would do over the girl you have dated since high school," Catra tells her, voice rolling in her laughter.

"As much as I want to be able to kiss you when we go out, I want *that* to not exist more. I don't like them thinking about you like that. Thinking about us. It isn't their business," Adora mutters, glaring up at her ceiling again. Catra is silent for a long moment.

"Adora, are you jealous?" Catra asks. Her voice is artfully neutral. Adora winces.

"It isn't their business. It's disrespectful," she responds, voice small from how weak she knows her argument is. Catra's purr rolls down the line, distorted and tinny.

"Don't worry, princess. I'm all yours tomorrow. They can imagine all they like, they don't get to *touch*," she tells her. Adora's entire body heats in response.

Chapter End Notes

I typed this whole chapter up in W ord, put it in AO3 to edit it, and at the last second hit CTRL+R and refreshed the AO3 page cuz I'm used to using that shortcut in W ord to shift it to right-aligned text. I think I've fixed all the editing and formatting but f c that sucked.

Thank to @spirites and @sash412 for leaving username suggestions in the comments! I'll be using some of them (or something similar) in the fic.

The Restaurant

Chapter Summary

> Adora has all notifications from people she does not follow turned off. Her phone is still blowing up with notifications as Rebellion and Frght-Z members start replying to the tweet. And texting her . Oh, look, a call from Bow.
> Adora sends Angella one last warning that she is turning off her phone and then powers it down to glare at Catra.

Chapter Notes

> it's the thirst update, finally . They're not wearing seatbelts because that's what rich people do in the back of their fancy rides according to movies.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They barely make it to the restaurant before Adora tells the driver to turn around the car. She can see the crowd already formed outside. She doesn't want them to get close enough for a camera flash to pierce its way through the tinted windows.

"They have *signs* , Adora. Three of them are phone numbers," Catra tells her, way too gleefully, leaning up to the window to watch the procession of obsessive behaviour that is her life now. Her tail is waving excitedly behind her . Catra is used to weirdness on the internet, but her fandom rarely enters her real life. Adora, on the other hand, has grown to love and dread concerts with equal measure. She has learned to never read the signs.

"Angella said she would call ahead to get us some privacy . I guess it didn't work," Adora grumbles, slouching in her seat. Catra laughs, reaching out blindly to pat her knee in comfort. She does not turn away from the window.

"Hey , this one has a *dawing* -" Catra starts, utter glee in her voice.

"Just take us back to Manhattan," Adora calls to the driver in the front seat, cutting Catra off before she can share something Adora will never unhear. Catra cackles beside her.

"Yes, ma'am," their driver , an elderly woman sporting a hijab and a kind smile, replies. She looks almost sorry for them when Adora catches her eye in the rearview mirror.

"This is your life now too, I hope you know that," Adora tells Catra. They have turned the corner past the main fan force now , and Catra turns back to her with no more signs left to read.

"Let me tweet something. From your account," she replies, eyes sparking with mischief. Her tail is *lashing* from her excitement and her pupils are blown out round. Adora feels the blood drain from her face.

"Do you want Angella to *kill* me?" she squeaks. The cunning spark hasn't left Catra's eyes as she crawls across the backseat, boxing Adora into the corner of the bench. Adora feels her body temperature rising several degrees as Catra settles in her lap, still grinning down at her with all *fangs*, hands sweeping along her body. If blood were actually flowing to Adora's brain right now, she would point out that they are in a moving vehicle, but-

Catra pulls away, all smug satisfaction as she settles back into her own seat. Adora is left dazed and confused, blinking blindly at the space where Catra had been - then she turns to her right and sees Catra holding a decidedly *cracked* phone in her hand. Her thumb is hovering over the unlock button, but despite the fact she just stole Adora's phone out of her suit jacket, she still looks at her questioningly , awaiting permission. Adora's brain still has not returned to full operation, so she just sighs and waves her off.

"Let me read it first," she concedes, trying to unlock some secret telekinetic powers that will give her the ability to will her blush down

and return her body to normal blood flow.

"I would tweet it from mine, but, you know , they don't know it's *me* ," Catra tells her, typing away furiously on Adora's phone. "Also, put a better password on this thing. That was my second guess," she adds as she turns the screen back to face Adora. Adora would point out there is not a single person on the planet other than her and Catra who could possibly understand her password, but she is too busy reading the drafted tweet before Catra decides to just send it anyway.

> **Adora Gayskill** *@adoragayskillz*
>
> If you tried to crash my date tonight, send me a pic of your signs. My girlfriend wants to make fun of me.
>
> 0 0 0

"Oh, so we're skipping Angella and just letting T witter kill me itself? My replies will never recover from this, Catra. You're *bating* them," Adora tells her, looking up to make eye contact and finding Catra *grinning* at her words. She does not break eye contact as she slowly and deliberately moves her thumb and presses *Send* . Adora narrows her eyes at her and snatches the phone from her hand. Catra cackles while Adora sends a desperate apology text to Angella.

"You could've stopped me," Catra points out. Adora sends a glare at her as Angella texts back to ask what she is apologizing for . Yes, Catra technically gave her plenty of opportunities to stop her, but they both know how hard it is for Adora to resist her.

Adora has all notifications from people she does not follow turned off; her phone is still blowing up with notifications as Rebellion and

Frght-Zmembers start replying to the tweet. And tekking her . Oh, look, a call from Bow. Adora sends Angella one last warning that she is turning off her phone and then powers it down. She looks up, glaring at a completely unapologetic Catra.

“W anna lay on your balcony and read the thirst tweets?” Catra asks her, still grinning. Her tail is still swaying behind her.

“I would rather be fulfilling some of them, but sure,” Adora shoots back. Despite the way it makes her own face heat, the blush spilling down Catra’s face in return is worth it.

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They manage to make it into their hotel without being intercepted. Their driver drops them of f in the parking garage, right nekto an elevator that will take them straight up to their floor. Rebellion’s head security officer, uliet, meets them there and ushers them inside. The parking garage is mercifully empty. Somehow the hotel where the entirety of Rebellion is staying for their NYC promotional tour is still a secret while the restaurant where Adora just wanted to get *one* normal evening is now public knowledge.

Catra wraps herself around Adora’s arm once they are in the elevator, uliet’ s presence thoroughly ignored, and purrs lightly when she notices how awkward it makes Adora. They haven’t gotten to be very affectionate since they actually settled things. Catra touched her constantly during the music video shoot, but it felt like a tenuous spell that was not *real* and would snap the moment they broke contact.

Now, having Catra pressing against her - in what is ostensibly a public space - makes Adora more flustered than she anticipated. Catra lets her go when they reach their floor, but she fixes Adora

with a look that is only a half-step below eye-fucking when she pulls away. Juliet clears her throat, and Catra turns to flash her a bright, innocent smile before she steps out of the elevator, Adora trailing behind her. It is not as bad as what the driver had to deal with, at least.

Adora leads Catra to her room, fumbling with the keycard for a moment before the door flings open all on its own. Adora startles back as Glimmer comes bursting out of her room for some reason, only a hair below *swinging*.

"Adora, you *bated* them?" she asks. Adora can't tell if it's anger or excitement in her voice. She looks desperately behind her to Catra, who looks ruffled for once by this unexpected change. Her eyes aren't on Glimmer, though. She is looking deeper into Adora's room. Adora follows her gaze to find the entirety of Rebellion gathered in her room.

"Meet the parents time, I guess," Catra mutters from behind her. If Adora didn't know her so well, she would miss the waver in her voice.

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They end up sitting leaned up against the headboard of Adora's bed, Catra in her arms and tensed like she is prepared for battle. Her appearance is relaxed, but Adora can feel the tension in her body where they are in contact. Rebellion, plus Sea Hawk, is gathered in a loose circle around them, sitting on chairs, the vanity, the floor, and even on Adora's suitcase. At least Angella is not in NYC with them. Depending on Glimmer's intent, she would either definitely be here or be decidedly *avoiding* the entire floor.

"So the restaurant went well," Adora tries. Glimmer levels her with a look and Adora shuts up. Catra lets out a small trill of approval, which would draw all focus to her if it weren't already there, but it still definitely intensifies. Catra's ears twitch like she wants to pin them back, but she remains still in Adora's arms.

"That's the first time I've seen someone else use that look on Adora successfully," Catra praises. It's mostly a defense for the sound. Catra used to hate making any of her more unique sounds in front of others, largely because of the teasing she endured as the only magicat in the home – and the entire city, probably. She had to work past that barrier when she started being hired for her racial traits, but years of childhood conditioning are hard to break.

"My mom can do it, too. Our manager, Angella," Glimmer clarifies. She looks appraisingly at Catra. It feels like the two girls are feeling each other out with their eyes, trying to understand their adversary. Adora does not know why everything surrounding Catra has to be a confrontation. Catra is defensive and mildly paranoid, but for some reason people think that means she wants to fight. She never has, Adora knows – that is *why* she has to be defensive.

"I know. I only missed a year and a half," Catra replies, rolling her eyes. She slinks a little further back into Adora's arms. Glimmer's gaze snaps to Adora at that. Adora *thought* they were over this, but apparently not.

"And yet we never met you until now," Glimmer adds, eyeing Adora. She doesn't actually look mad, she just needs to rub it in, apparently. Adora doesn't flinch – she makes no apologies for that. She had her reasons, and they were good ones.

"I feel like I'm being grilled by my mom for breaking curfew," Adora complains, squeezing Catra a little tighter. She doesn't want to be having this conversation, and she isn't even sure what this conversation *is* yet. Catra laughs at Adora's comparison. Glimmer, in contrast, *spites*.

"I am not *motherly* ," Glimmer protests. Unfortunately for her , a murmur runs through the entire group that thoroughly disproves her sentiment. Glimmer turns to Bow, clutching at his arm desperately. "Bow , tell them I'm not motherly ," she instructs. Bow casts around desperately, saying nothing and *sweating* .

Glimmer is technically right – she is closer to an excitable puppy than the mom friend, but at the same time she often has to be the one to wrangle them just to avoid disappointing her mom. Add in how caring and understanding she can be, and *motherly* doesn't sound so wrong anymore.

"Look, I know Glimmer is having a crisis, but why the hell is Sea Hawk here?" Catra asks, gesturing to where Sea Hawk is sitting on the floor so Mermista can put her feet up on his shoulders from her spot in the weird corner armchair that had been included in the room. Catra sounds suspicious, which is odd. According to Sea Hawk, when Adora asked him very unsubtly at the time, Catra and Sea Hawk had gotten along on the two sets where they had crossed paths.

Adora also can't imagine Sea Hawk going that long without mentioning his obsession with Mermista, but maybe he is more professional when he is actually working. Okay, actually, *definitely* not.

"He's my ride," Mermista replies, not even glancing down at her living footrest. Sea Hawk nods proudly.

"He crashed his last three cars. He crashed one on the *way to set* . We had to delay the entire shoot because we couldn't get that location again for a week," Catra points out. She is looking at Mermista like she has lost her mind, but she doesn't look suspicious anymore at least.

"Last four , actually!" Sea Hawk corrects, far too happily . Catra gives him a look that clearly says *you're being stupid again* . Sea Hawk remains unaffected, despite the intensity of the look. It seems like

Sea Hawk didn't exaggerate them getting along, then. If he can just absorb that look from Catra, he probably wouldn't be bothered by anything else she would be willing to do while having to be professional on set.

"He's Mermista's boyfriend," Adora clarifies for her, because Mermista certainly won't say it despite it having been *years*. Sea Hawk beams at the same time as Mermista looks at Adora with mild offense.

"I have no idea what you're talking about. I don't date actors," Mermista replies. Catra narrows her eyes at Mermista, tail flicking in contained irritation as she clearly tries to take Mermista apart in her mind, trying to determine if that was meant to be an insult aimed at her.

"Catra, we have some questions prepared for you now that your evening has been cleared," Bow announces, drawing attention away from the tension between Catra and Mermista as he pulls out a legal pad seemingly from thin air. Catra's eyes snap to him and she narrows them almost imperceptibly.

"You leaked the location of the restaurant to force us into your ambush," Catra accuses, outright glaring at Bow now. Bow looks startled.

"No, Bow isn't like that, I promise," Adora jumps in, moving one hand to rest it on Catra's shoulder. She *gets it*, Bow couldn't have worded that more suspiciously if he tried, but she knows that isn't true. Angella got them reservations and it was a mistake. Rebellion saw the tweet Catra sent out right away and had plenty of time while they drove back to the hotel to decide on launching the ambush.

"You trust everybody," Catra shoots back, turning her narrowed gaze on Adora now. Not actually true, but Adora is far more trusting than Catra, as least. Despite her words, Catra relaxes back into Adora's arms, trusting her to have made the right judgement call with Bow.

Catra sighs, waving her hand in the air in a clear *go ahead* motion to Bow as she settles further back into Adora's embrace.

"Okay , first! Catra, what are your intentions with Adora?" Bow requests, making a clear tick on his pad before looking up at her . Catra stares at him, eyes wide and lips parted in open confusion at the question. It is laughable, really . Their entire lives, they were always watching each other's backs – always risking it all to protect the other or just do something that would make them *smile* . Adora is sure that Catra would be offended that somebody else is trying to defend Adora *from* her if she weren't so surprised by it.

"Well, I *was* planning to desecrate the lounge seat on the balcony with her, but then you guys showed up," Catra responds when she manages to recover from her shock. At least she is not offended – yet – but Adora chokes just a little, turning her face away to cough into her hand and avoid the pointed looks her bandmates are now giving her. She isn't embarrassed, but it is *surprising* , and maybe a touch exciting.

"I was thinking more long-term, like if you believe in marriage and that kind of thing?" Bow tries, clearly a little flustered by her response. Adora suddenly remembers some promises between children in third grade that she definitely clung a little too hard to after Catra left - some promises she wrote and released a song for, even if no one but Catra could realize it - and decides that *now* she is embarrassed.

"Bow , please?" Adora tries, voice still a little watery as she tries to recover from her choking fit with *that* on her mind. She and Catra never talked about it before – it was the last thing on their mind when they were just struggling to feed themselves - and it certainly is not the time *now*. Bow shoots her an apologetic look, but Glimmer has no such qualms. She cuts straight to the heart of the matter .

"How do we know you aren't going to leave again and break her heart?" Glimmer demands, leaning forward. She is not outright

glaring at Catra, but it is close enough. Adora feels her blood turn to ice.

"*I* broke her heart?" Catra demands, incredulous, sitting forward so suddenly she leaves Adora's arms. Adora's chest is tight with panic. This can't be happening, not *tonight*. Everything has been going so well, and Adora can feel it beginning to crumble beneath her fingers.

"It was my fault that you put so much pressure on her I hardly got to see my girlfriend anymore? That you needed so damn much from her that *you* convinced me our relationship was worthless to her, that *I* was worthless? It was my fault that you worked her until she *broke*, and when I begged her to take a break, she was on tour again the next day for *you*? It's *my* fault that I had to watch the woman I love kill herself from a distance because I couldn't stand to see it up close anymore?" Catra demands, her voice rising in anger and volume as she goes.

The entire room blinks at her in the stunned silence that follows, Adora included. The panic is gone now, replaced by something much darker, much *heavier*. Guilt nearly chokes her. Catra draws in a sharp breath, eyes going wide and ears pinning back to her head as she seems to realize what she just said. Adora may be in minor shock over Catra's statement, but that look triggers a deep-rooted protective instinct in her.

"Get out," Adora says, voice quiet but *hard*. It is all she can manage as she wraps her arms around Catra's waist again, pulling her back against her chest so she can assure herself with the feeling of her breathing, here and in her arms. Glimmer winces, guilt obvious as she stands silently with the rest of the group members and leaves with only an apologetic look thrown back over her shoulder. The moment the door closes behind them, Catra turns into Adora's embrace and begins to cry against her shoulder.

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"I love you," Adora promises her, after Catra has managed to calm her down from her combination crying session and panic attack.

"I know. I- I you too. I just didn't *then*. If I felt that bitterness for so long, it just comes back sometimes," Catra tells her, face still tucked into her shoulder, idly twining Adora's loose hair between her claws as a distraction. Their breathing has steadied now, their chests rising and falling in sync.

"When I listened to *Heartstrings*, I realized how wrong I was about the whole thing, but I still couldn't bring myself to watch you do that to yourself. I almost called you so many times. I almost went to parties I knew you would be at. That's why I went to the award show, after avoiding you for so long. That and- I needed to see what happened with the album. How people reacted to our story," Catra explains.

"When you were on stage, all I could think was *I love you too*. I wanted to come back to you so badly, but I was afraid of losing you to yourself, and I couldn't go through that again," Catra whispers, her voice thick with emotions. Adora's heart *breaks*.

"You won't. I promise," Adora tells her, pulling her just a little bit closer. Catra gasps at the words. Adora feels the clench in her stomach, knowing exactly what Catra is remembering - the same thing she had remembered, earlier that night. The promise that is the subject of Rebellion's song *God And Self*.

"I'm sorry about them ambushing you. I- I don't think they would've done it if they knew," Adora tells her. She wants Catra to know her bandmates aren't *assholes*, but that isn't the only reason she says it. Catra stirs in her arms, looking up at her with searching eyes. At least she doesn't look sad, or guilty, or *angry* anymore.

"You want to tell them?" she asks, her voice soft and unsure. Adora could never look away from that gaze. She nods, their eyes still

locked.

"They don't need all the details, but they've really been there for me through everything. They were constantly trying to get me to take time off too, you know. I just couldn't let myself do it. I was too afraid that the second I stopped working, it would all go away . Until you," she says, nudging Catra's shoulder lightly.

"Until me," Catra echoes, softly , biting her lip and looking away. After a long moment of internal debate, she sighs, meeting Adora's eyes again. "Okay . You can tell the band - and your manager, I guess. As long as they can keep their mouths shut," Catra agrees, dropping her head back to Adora's shoulder. Making a decision seems to drain all her remaining energy. Her body goes lax in a way that is less *relaxed* and more *exhausted past the point of retaining any tension* .

"Thank you," Adora responds, turning to pressing soft kisses into her hair. A low rumble of acknowledgement rolls through her girlfriend. For a moment, they just sit like that, the air hanging heavy around them. It is just a touch hard to breathe, still. The previous trajectory for the evening isn't right, not anymore, but an earlier suggestion of Catra's comes to her mind. Adora wanted nothing to do with it then, but now they could use the levity.

"Hey ," Adora says, nudging Catra with the shoulder she is leaning against. Catra raises her head, blinking at her a bit blearily. "Want to read those terribly horny replies to your tweet now?" she asks. A small smile slowly spreads across Catra's face.

"You mean *your* tweet?" she corrects, lifting herself in Adora's arms to readjust so she can lay on top of her again, letting Adora look over her shoulder as she pulls her cracked phone out of the pocket of her suit pants.

"Unfortunately ," Adora agrees, but she breathes easier seeing *elation* seeping back into Catra's body.

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Adora Gayskill @adoragayskill • 2d

f you tried to crash my date tonight, send me a pic of your signs. My girlfriend wants to make fun of me.

@bookoless • 2d • Reply to @adoragayskill

Mine got torn on the subway coming home but it was the one that said “Can Igrind on your abs”

@thasoade • 2d • Reply to @adoragayskill

WAIT GRLFRENDSELFSHIP WAS JUST SUPPOSED TO BE A PHASE. YOU CANT BE TAKEN

@eagh • 2d • Reply to @adoragayskill

Mine said “dont break her heart”Irealized when Igot there that most people were going in a different direction

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@organcta • 2d • Reply to @adoragayskill

Okay it doesnt photograph well because of the glitter but it says bench me adora. pls

[MG213]

@adoraspntyal • 2 • Eyg to @doragsku

Im not going to tweet a picture so Idont get flagged but mine was the one with the drawing with earmuffs. Im not ashamed

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@tf f inthenk • 2 • Eyg to @doragsku

are u a uhaul lesbian or

Chapter End Notes

Yes the Sword & Shield song is about their promise from the show, and also lowkey the backstory behind Adoras back tattoo, but more on both of those later lol
Never in my life have Iseen a hotel with a balcony in NYC, at least not in Manhattan, but Im standing by this one. Honestly havent seen many balconies at all. There is probably some kind of city ordinance but Idont care this hotel has balconies.

The Public

Chapter Summary

> "Your fans are cruel, you know that? At least mine just ask me to choke them out with my tail or something," Catra tells her, rolling onto her side to nuzzle into Adora's shoulder. Adora glares at the sky above her, imagining Catra getting those tweets, or worse yet having that fan interaction in person.
> "We should come out," she decides.

Chapter Notes

> This update is a good time to mention that while homophobia does exist in-universe, it is more rare/generally less intense. There are still some people who feel it strongly, but it isn't super common.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So, the new song you're performing for us today, it is a love song, isn't it?" Kingston asks. The talk show set's lighting is bright, but Adora knows the flush on her cheeks has nothing to do with the heat of the lights.

"Yes, it is," she agrees, feeling Glimmer lean in to nudge her a little playfully. She shoves her bandmate away lightly, rolling her eyes at the face Glimmer pulls in return. She knows their fans – in twenty minutes there will be dozens of gifs of the moment on Twitter.

"Now, am I right in assuming that you recently got some new inspiration on that front?" Kingston asks, faux-coy as the screen behind him pulls up a screenshot of Adora's tweet from last night. Thankfully, the image doesn't include any of the replies. It wouldn't be safe for television anymore. Another image pulls up, this one showing her tweet about love from Tuesday. Adora knows her blush is furious, but she just shrugs and shakes her head.

"I wouldn't call the inspiration new. It's just hard to make things work, between how busy our schedules are and having to dodge fans for a private moment," Adora settles on saying. She and Catra talked this morning, when they had woken up groggy in each other's arms after passing out scrolling through Twitter. They were still in their wrinkled suits from the night before, and Adora's eyes stung from leaving her contacts in, but it had still been nice to wake up together again. They decided there was no use in denying that they were each dating someone. They didn't want to, either, despite their fears.

"Why worry about a private moment when you are just going to put it in a song?" Kingston asks, teasing and light, but Adora feels her blush fading as his words strike a chord in her. She can *feel* herself getting intense, but she can't help it as her brows draw together.

"Those moments are only song-worthy because we share them. They only mean anything because they belong to us. We might be celebrities, we might even be out, but our relationship is *ours*," Adora explains, gesturing animatedly as she talks. Kingston looks the kind of touched that only a showman can muster—that is to say, it's a look of utter bullshit.

"Sentiment like that shows why you are such an impressive lyricist, Adora," he tells her. Adora takes the compliment with a gracious smile, even if she does not believe it for a second. She knows the best actress out there—Kingston does not come even close to comparing. Besides, he makes it sound like *having emotions* is a foreign concept to him. She wills her body to relax from her sudden passion.

"But you said you are both celebrities? Does that mean you are dating another singer?" he presses, and Adora has to suppress an eyeroll at him immediately dismissing her supposedly *touching* point. Clearly she made a big impression on him.

"We decided a long time ago that our relationship is private. Our friends know and that's all that matters to us," Adora replies, leaning back on the couch in a clear gesture that this line of questioning

should end if he ever wants them to come back. He obviously doesn't want to, but Kingston drops it, turning to ask Mermista a question about the car accident she got in with Sea Hawk a few weeks back instead.

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Catra is still in her hotel room when she gets back, her flight back to LA not leaving until that evening. Rebellion still has another night show to tape before they head back in the early morning. As much as four AM flights suck, she is glad for the relative anonymity they offer.

Perhaps in preparation for her flight, Catra has changed into a pair of sweats and an almost indecently-tight sweater, the sleeves of a giant cardigan rolled up her arms, but she is lounging out on the pool bed on balcony, seemingly content to soak in the usually-warm winter sun with the privacy of the balcony's solid wall of railing protecting her from street view.

"Kingston got just as nosy as you predicted," Adora tells her when she opens the balcony door. Catra lolls her head back, looking her up and down carefully. She is assessing to see if Adora is really upset, she knows. She sends Catra the same look all the time.

"I watched it. You handled him well, though," Catra praises, scooting over on the narrow lounge. Her tail thumps the seat beside her in an unspoken invitation and then sweeps into her lap to get out of the way.

"A fan saw you leaving the hotel this morning. There has been a gathering of them on the street ever since. One of them brought a sign for *you*," Catra informs her, smirking a bit when Adora rolls her eyes at Catra's perverse delight. Adora moves to lay out on the

lounge beside Catra, throwing an arm around her waist. The space is cramped, forcing their bodies into contact in an incredibly convenient way.

"I know," Juliet warned us. "Do I want to know what the sign said?" Adora asks. Catra grins a little.

"We need more breakup songs.' Your fans are cruel, you know that? At least mine just ask me to choke them out with my tail or something," Catra tells her, rolling onto her side to nuzzle into Adora's shoulder. Adora *glares* at the sky above her, imagining Catra getting those tweets, or worse yet, having that fan interaction *in person*.

"We should come out," Adora decides. Catra laughs, delighted as she props her chin up on her hand to look down at Adora. Her eyes dance with amusement over Adora's jealousy. Adora knows, deep down, that them announcing their relationship would do nothing to dissuade people from thinking about Catra that way—or even *messaging* her, truthfully—but the fantasy is nice all the same.

"Princess, that is nothing compared to the shit I have seen about you. Although I do follow the Instagram dedicated to your abs. That is worthy content," Catra tells her, smirk firmly in place as Adora blushes. Adora cannot let a challenge go unanswered, however, so she rolls onto her side as well, pressing along Catra's front and reveling in the way her breath stutters at the contact.

"You don't need an Instagram when I'm right here," Adora points out, the arm she is not propped against moving to grip Catra's waist, squeezing lightly. It is bold, but Catra has been *insinuating* since Friday. Catra's pupils dilate, gaze darting down to the hem of Adora's shirt before coming back up to her face. Catra licks her lips. Adora would be fool enough to believe it was an unconscious gesture if she did not look so smug at the way Adora's gaze follows the action.

Adora does not need any further encouragement—she never does, with Catra. Any opening into her life, her heart, her *touch* that Catra

offers, Adora happily takes. She leans forward, nudging Catra's cheek slightly to encourage her to angle back, meeting her easily when she does. The kiss is soft and slow, but deep from the start. Catra's free hand comes up to wrap around the back of Adora's head, holding her in place so she can keep the kiss going at her slow, languid pace.

It is almost torture to finally be tasting Catra again and be held *back*, but she has no intention of rushing Catra into a level of intimacy she is uncomfortable with. That thought goes flying out the window when the hand in her hair drops to her shoulder and Adora finds herself pushed down so she is lying on her back, Catra crawling on top of her and grinning down at her in anticipation.

"Want to make a *different* sign come true?" she asks. Adora swallows, feeling her gut clench without even knowing what Catra is planning.

"Happily," she replies.

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Catra Cyra Opens Up About Being Outed & Making a Celebrity Lesbian Relationship Work

"I was outed, I guess, but I was never in the closet to begin with."

Article by Staff Contributor Bookie Z

According to Catra Cyra's friends, she is a lot of things. We had the honour of sitting down with her and her long-time friends, the idol group Frght-Z, at a concert in LA this Wednesday. Frght-Z is an all-sapphic fronted band. Catra went to high school with two of its members and is almost an unofficial part of the band. The band used

many words to describe Catra. "Hardworking," "mischievous," "dramatic," "caring," "loyal," and our favourite, "mean, but in a kind-hearted way."

Another word they used was "lesbian."

A week ago, Catra Cyra was publicly outed after an anonymous source on the set for her current film, *You Won't Be Told*, leaked a private phone conversation between her and her girlfriend. Catra's now-infamous response was a one-sentence tweet: "If you thought I was straight then that's on you."

We had the pleasure of sitting down with Catra and asking her questions about navigating love and the industry as a lesbian.

Your response to the initial article was very blasé. Was that really all you felt, or were you more bothered by being outed than you let on?

"I was more bothered by how disrespectful and presumptive the initial article was than anything else. I was outed, I guess, but I was never in the closet to begin with. I spend all my time hanging out with other gays, and I know there is a photo online of me and Scorpia from school when I still had my dyke haircut. My sexuality was something I decided early on I wouldn't make a big deal of, but I wouldn't hide either. I already did that in high school, thanks."

It has only been a week, but have you noticed people treating you differently professionally?

"Yeah, one or two people on set are clearly uncomfortable with me now, and my agent has been scrambling over what this means for my career, but I said at the very beginning I wasn't going to play straight. Honestly, the biggest difference so far is the tweets I have been getting ever since. I prefer the horny messages from sapphics over the ones from straight guys, but the slurs are getting real tiring."

This whole thing started because of a conversation with your girlfriend. What does she think of the situation?

"My girlfriend is used to this kind of thing. She knows a bit of what it's like to be in the public eye, so she is really understanding. We're both very private people, so we just want to keep the details of our relationship to ourselves."

Is it difficult to maintain a relationship with so much public pressure?

"Very. Any celebrity relationship is hard, but as lesbians, we have a different experience than straight couples do. It certainly doesn't make it easier, but we make each other happier at the end of the day. It's worth what we have to go through if we get to be together, but it can be hard knowing straight couples don't have to deal with as much as we do."

You recently starred in your first romantic role as the lesbian love interest in Rebellion's new music video for their single "Hero." What is your philosophy around acting in romantic roles, especially pretending to be straight?

"Like I said, I decided early on I would not play straight. That includes acting professionally. I have played roles that had some romantic tension with male leads, but that is as far as I'll go. My acting skills have nothing to do with my repulsion to the idea of kissing a man, especially forcing myself to do it for a job. It narrows down my role choices, but it is a line I am privileged to be able to draw and still have options available to me. I would love to play a lesbian in a larger role than a three-minute music video, but there aren't a lot of roles out there for us yet, especially that aren't overly sexual."

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The end of the US leg of Frght-Z s world tour is the best excuse that Adora can find to make her way into LA again, even though Catra wont *be* there. She had an interview alongside them on Wednesday, but Adora already had a practice arranged with Rebellion and had to settle on a phone call that night. The celebratory party is the next day, so Adora attends it knowing that she can meet up with Catra at her apartment in a few hours, after she is done filming. Besides, it has been ages since she caught up with Scorpia, especially without Perfuma around, tying their hands on conversation topics.

"I cant tell you how happy I am that you and Wildcat patched things up. She was miserable without you," Scorpia tells her , clapping her on the back hard enough she almost knocks Adora over. Adora would point out that they are in public, but the VIP area of the club that BME has rented out for the party is mostly filled with people on BME's bankroll right now. These people she trusts to keep their mouths shut, if only to keep their jobs. Besides, what Scorpia said wasn't damning.

"The feeling is mutual. I was a disaster without her ," Adora replies, taking the drink Scorpia offers her and raising it in a vague cheers motion. She doesn't actually take a sip. She wants to be sober for Catra later and Frght-Z often goes hard at these kinds of things. She wants to be able to keep an eye out for her friends, even if she is sure their bodyguards can handle it if needed. Scorpia levels her with her best *no bullsht* look – it is a very poor one.

"You were *always* a disaster, Adora, even when we were kids. You were convinced that if you just tried hard enough, Weaver wouldn't be able to get mad this time," Scorpia points out, voice low . Adora winces, glancing around, but she has to nod. She knows where her issues come from and she doesn't need to draw attention by arguing with the truth.

fwas worse without her . Im working on it. Ill treat her right this time, Ipromise,"Adora tells Scorpia, eager to deflect of f that conversation track. t' s unnerving to see Scorpia, always so light and bright, get still and deadly serious. Adora has seen it happen before, but seeing such a dark look in her eye is so rare it still throws her off.

"Y oud better ,"Scorpia threatens. Adora holds her breath and nods, not breaking eye contact despite how wide her eyes have gotten. Scorpia instantly breaks into her happy, sunshine smile, the dark look dissolving. Im happy for you two,"she adds, apparently satisfied Adora is not going to hurt Catra again.

Thanks,"Adora manages, a bit weakly , still recovering from being on the receiving end of Scorpia's intensity.

"W e bullying Adora for being a dumbass?Lonnie asks from her right, causing Adora to startle and look over. Lonnie has her hand on Entrapta's arm, clearly doing her best to keep her fellow idol from wandering off before the party even begins. Entrapta, for her part, just waves happily at Adora, unbothered by being dragged along. Emily and Darla are both trailing behind her , apparently all too happy to let Lonnie deal with wrangling *their* girlfriend.

"Bullying over , now were celebrating!T o some happy love songs, yeah?"Scorpia corrects, raising her glass. Adora blushes, but she raises hers as well. After they cheers, Scorpia throws her drink back in one go.

t is going to be a long night.

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Adora Gayskill *@adoragayskill · Tuesday 6*

Congrats to Frght-Zor a fantastic US tour!So proud of you ladies 3 And dont worry if you were at the afterparty!The property damage was minor and Scorpia is fine!She's very happy with her Hello Kitty bandaid

---

@frightzone • 4Eng to @adoragayskill

Dude Iwas there!The table smash was epic

@stephaniehading2 • 4Eng to @adoragayskill

Adora you cant say "dont worry"and then follow it up with the phrase "property damage"wtf that' s not how twit works

---

@wtf sadora • 4Eng to @adoragayskill

did your girlfriend come?

@nineten • 4Eng to @adoragayskill

Wtf happened?property damage?is everyone ok?Why are you the one tweeting about this and not the band

---

@pchenscopia • 4Eng to @adoragayskill and @nineten

@nineten ok so i was there it was epic Scorpia got wasted and broke a table in half trying to LEAN on it because her biceps

are so big that when she's drunk it turns into a piledrive. im still wet just from watching it tbh

--

Catra's apartment may be small, but it has a fantastic balcony that looks out over the LA skyline, glittering with artificial lights at the late hour. A small planter box sits in the corner next to a lawn chair.

"So Melog gets some greenery. It's probably about the same as what he would get at a public park in this city anyway," Catra explains when Adora looks at the planter questioningly. She didn't exactly have the time to look around the last time she came over, too focused on taking care of Catra and then later Melog until she realized she was going to be late to the studio.

"Scorpia had Perfuma set it up for me," Catra elaborates as she leads Adora back inside. She settles them on the couch, rolling her eyes when Adora sits beside her. She pushes Adora's shoulder, encouraging her to lie back, and then drapes across her chest. Adora lets out a happy sigh, wrapping her arms around her girlfriend and turning her head to steal a quick kiss.

It was supposed to be a quick kiss, anyway. She can't help the way that Catra draws her in, intoxicating to all her senses and drowning out all other thoughts. Her body moves of its own accord, one hand sneaking beneath the hem of Catra's lounge shirt and the other burying in her hair. Sometimes she feels like she has no control when it comes to Catra, the other girl pulling her in like a siren song that makes her lose all reason.

Catra is her favourite possession, Adora thinks, and that trail of thought spirals out until she finds she is humming into the kiss. After

a few seconds, Catra pulls back from the kiss, her eyes dancing with amusement as she looks down at Adora.

"You were writing lyrics just now, weren't you?" she asks, a touch breathless. There is a shining love on her face, a ghost of familiarity in the moment. Adora feels like she has no air left in her lungs, so she merely nods. Catra's answering smile is soft and touched. "Go ahead," Catra tells her. The familiarity of it all makes Adora's heart pound as she wrestles her phone out of her jeans pocket and begins typing a note over Catra's back, her arms still wrapped around her. This isn't the first time this has happened, but it *is* the first time in two years.

"Does it have a name, yet?" Catra asks, pressing a kiss to Adora's jaw and causing her thumbs to skitter across her phone's keyboard for a moment.

"Possession, I think," Adora manages, gasping softly as Catra nips lightly at the side of her neck, fangs just grazing her skin. After a brief pause, she types out another line. Catra's rumble rises between them for a moment before she latches onto the side of Adora's neck with a bite that causes her back to arch off the couch with a soft cry. "*Catra*," she breathes, her voice sounding like an admonishment, though she is not sure for *what*. She types out another line.

"You know how to use concealer," Catra teases before latching on again to make another dark mark, fangs sharp against her skin. Ah, right, that is what she should be scolding Catra for – if her higher thought processes were working at all. "Or you can leave it. Show them you are *taken*," Catra punctuates the sentiment with another sharp bite, Adora's phone falling out of her shaking hands and getting lost somewhere in the sofa as she moans.

"Everyone knows that, anyway," Adora points out, but she brings up her now-free hands to bury them in Catra's hair. Catra doesn't seem to like that argument – the next bite is harsh and painful, sending a thrill through Adora's core as she lets out a soft cry.

"You're *mine*," is Catra's reply, almost down to a growl. Adora lets out a soft whine, no rebuttal left for that statement. It occurs to her that perhaps Catra heard the wrong definition of *possession*, but she certainly is not *complaining*. She might even explore the double meaning in the lyrics, now, when she has that kind of room in her brain again.

"Yours," she agrees in a soft pant. Catra *does* growl now, hands coming up to Adora's chest. Adora realizes suddenly that Catra's claws are out now.

"I hope you don't like this dress, princess. Enough other people have seen you in it," Catra threatens. It isn't much a threat – Adora shakes her head eagerly to prove she doesn't, in fact, give a shit about the bodycon dress she threw on to not feel out of place in the club.

Catra grins, all teeth and fangs, as she tucks her claws inside the collar of the dress and pulls down, claws ripping it from collar to hem. Adora gasps at the sudden rush of air against her. Catra's grin is feral as she so-casually trails her claws down Adora's exposed front, leaving pink trails in her skin as she goes. Adora whines, thighs clenching, at the intensity in Catra's gaze.

"I think I need to *mark* my territory," Catra says, conversationally, claws dancing across Adora's hips infuriatingly lightly. Her hand reaches the waistband of Adora's underwear, and Adora gives up on finding words again with a quiet moan.

--

"Catra's name was always the main candidate in the rumours about who you were seeing," Angella points out, raising an eyebrow at Adora. Adora is doing her best to sink down in her seat, despite the glass of the conference table giving her nowhere to hide. The

overhead projector is still showing the blurry paparazzi photos of Adora walking out of Catra's apartment building, down the street, and getting into her recognizable muscle car.

Despite the blurriness, the fang impressions on Adora's neck stand out. Fans had quickly recognized the hoodie Adora borrowed as one that Catra wore to a Frght-Zone concert last year – her MO distressing is very distinctive. It took the internet all of three minutes to put it together. Add them going back through all the tweets of the fan who outed Adora as having a girlfriend initially and the rumour was all but confirmed.

Angella texted Adora immediately, looping Catra into a group chat between the three of them. They all agreed to wait a day to gauge the reaction. Adora spent most of Friday on the phone with Catra between shots, talking about absolutely nothing but fueled by an unspoken fear of hanging up and finding the other gone somehow. Now it is Saturday, and despite knowing this meeting was coming, Adora is no more prepared for it.

"You knew this was inevitable," Angella adds.

"Why does everyone keep saying that?" Adora mutters, still not making eye contact. That was the same phrasing Catra used when they were first spotted, too. *Inevitable*. Nothing is inevitable. They are living proof of that, overcoming the odds that they have. Adora sighs, sending Angella an apologetic look. It really isn't her fault. "I'm just - scared," she admits. Glimmer places a light hand on her shoulder, sending her an empathetic look. A *talk to us* look. Adora sighs again, looking away.

"Now people know, it just feels like they are going to try to take her from me again," Adora explains. She catches Perfuma's eye and sees the look of understand there. Perfuma has been through a lot at the hands of the public as an openly trans lesbian, especially in the idol world. She knows what it is like to have fame take things away from her. Still, she cannot know how deep the sentiment runs for Adora.

"Fan reactions have been positive. There is always the obsessive contingent that believes they are your one true love and that she isn't good enough for you, but aside from that, Catra has been welcomed with open arms. She has been on the fandom's radar for a while thanks to her friendship with Frght-Zeven before the music video for *Bad* properly introduced her," Angella tries to assure her .

It eases Adora a little bit, but it does not address the root of the matter – the way public pressure drove Adora to self-sacrifice or the ever-present fear related to their relationship being known. Adora never even got far enough in her worry to wonder if the fanbase would accept Catra.

"*Bad* has had its views skyrocket. It just crossed 43 million. The fans are calling you 'Catradora'," Bow jumps in, showing her his phone. He has the video pulled up so she can see the stats on the view count climbing. Adora sends him a grateful smile, but it is hollow. She knows they are just trying to help, but they aren't *succeeding* .

"Is Catra okay with the attention?" Perfuma asks, suddenly . Adora startles, looking up to find Perfuma's eyes boring into her. Perfuma can tell there is more that is wrong and that Adora isn't saying, even if she has zeroed in on the wrong thing as the issue. Adora lets out a shaky breath. She *has* been saying what is wrong, they just haven't understood – because they can't, not when they only know so little.

"She slides between finding it funny and getting possessive of me. So, normal for her. We-" Adora cuts off, looking down at her feet. It has been a week. There is no better time than when they are all gathered like this, and they are *asking* , even if they don't know it. "Catra gave me permission to tell you why , back in New York. I just wasn't ready myself yet. It' s- time you know," she says softly .

Chapter End Notes

No I didn't change their in-canon shipname. tif fintherink started the catdora updates account, but catradora is how their

shipname caught on in the fandom. tiffintherink is absolutely bitter about it. t' s my reference to how the crew had different names for almost all the ships.
Ialso had the article that outed Catra call Frght-Zan all-lesbian fronted group, whereas the article in this chapter more aptly called it an all-sapphic fronted group seeing as there are bi members.

Outrunning

Chapter Summary

> "I didn't mean to get caught," Adora fires back, flopping back against her sofa and glaring up at the ceiling. Catra draws in a shaking breath on the other end of the line.
> "I know," she says softly.

Chapter Notes

> I know I said this was the fluff AU but idk how you want me to write catradora without there being some childhood trauma.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The table shifts around her, people stirring as they send glances back and forth to each other. No one seems to understand what that means. Angella's expression is artfully blank, but there is a sour twist to her mouth that tells Adora she has suspicions about what she is about to say.

Not the Angella knows, not really, but she was the one who scouted Adora. She saw how bad their situation was once they got out, even without details or ever meeting Catra. Adora sighs, sitting up in her seat and straightening her back. She prepares for battle – but she still keeps her eyes downcast. She doesn't want to see pity.

"Catra and I are both orphans. We were raised in a really homophobic group foster home together basically from infancy. Catra was outed first and the lady running it, Shadow, she said if Catra was going to act like a boy then she was going to look like one too. She forcibly cut her hair off in front of all of us," Adora pauses, taking a deep breath herself at the same time as she hears several of her friends draw in sharp ones.

"Shadow was always doing stuff like that to us. Worse, sometimes. When it became clear I wasn't straight either, she blamed Catra for *turning me gay*. We had to be so careful after that, hiding who we were and how we felt about each other," Adora explains, gaze fixed on the worn toes of her converse through the glass table. "They spent most of their teenage years sneaking around, well aware what would happen if they got caught.

"When I got scouted, it was like a Hail Mary. We didn't want to hide who we were anymore, but—that's why you never met her, before. Why we came out but kept each other secret. Even though we knew that it was an old mindset, we grew up dominated by it. It was hard enough to take the risk of being out. It felt too dangerous for people to know about us after having to hide it for so long," Adora explains, gesturing vaguely in the direction of the projector screen.

She still doesn't look up. She was vague, she used some allusions even, but the one example she gave is enough to extrapolate the rest. She knows that even without saying it, her bandmates know. There have been several sharp intakes of breath while she was talking, and Bow is *definitely* crying, but she doesn't know how to provide comfort. She doesn't know *why* she would either.

It was terrible - there was no positive aside from the fact that it is over now. Adora looks up, fixing her gaze determinedly on the projector photos. She can see angry and teary eyes out of her periphery, but she resolutely ignores it. If she doesn't press on now, she will never finish what she needs to say.

"That is why I am afraid. But I don't want to hide anymore, and neither does she. I don't want to talk about our past. I'm only telling you now so you can understand. Scorpia and Lonnie grew up with us, so they know, but I still don't want it to leave this room, and I certainly don't want the public to know. Still—that is why," Adora finishes, swallowing thickly.

Her eyes are burning. She closes them, drawing a deep breath and feeling the way it makes the raised lines on her hips and stomach

from Catra's claws burn as they stretch with the rise and fall. Catra was careful with her –she always is –but she was firm enough to leave lingering marks. t feels good to have physical proof on her skin that Catra is with her and still a part of her life, even if she isnt in the room.

"Thank you for telling us, Adora. Y ou're incredibly brave to have gone through what you have and still be standing –both of you are. Most people would not have the strength to be kind and honest the way you are after all that," Angella says, voice soft and rough with emotion. Adora startles, meeting her eyes without really meaning to and finding tears there.

Adora is used to compliments by now. She got desensitized to meaningless praise after their first album went platinum. Genuine compliments still strike a deep chord in her, and this praise is not meaningless. t could be hollow , maybe, from someone else, but Angella is visibly touched and struggling.

Adora swallows thickly and closes her eyes, willing her body to calm itself. Glimmer and Bow both have a hand on either of her shoulders now, though she isnt sure how long that has been true. She lets herself hang her head and have a moment to let the emotions stirring in her body run their course. She takes a shaking breath and looks up again.

"I think I want to make a statement, but I have to check with Catra first."

--

Me and @catracyra are both very private people. My music isn't an invitation into our relationship. Our love is just between the two of us. We've been together for years & we request that people respect us. We will share the parts of our lives we are comfortable with.

  

Adora Gaynell @adoragaynell · 5Feb
Replying to @adoragaynell

The rest is just for us. We've been together since high school, but I wrote most of Heartstrings during a period when we were broken up from the stress that Rebellion put on our lives. Catra is supportive of my music and I support her acting career completely.

Catra @catracyra · 4Feb
Replying to @adoragaynell

Translation: All I want is one normal date that doesn't end up on the internet. And for christ's sake stop thirst tweeting me. You can get in line.

--

"You added the thirst tweeting part," Adora accuses without any heat. She found it funny, honestly. Catra just hums down the phone line in satisfaction.

"Serves you right for getting spotted. I have to go, or Adora. I have two months left on my lease, but Melog can only take so much fan screaming interrupting his balcony naps. There is no point renting an

apartment for *stabty* if Icould get more rest at a hotel. Ihave to do my hair when Igo on runs to seven-eleven now ,"Catra complains. Adora winces, but Catra doesnt actually sound that annoyed - at least not at *her*.

"Ididnt mean to get caught,"she fires back, flopping back against her sofa and glaring up at the ceiling. Catra draws in a shaking breath on the other end of the line.

"Iknow , Adora,"she says softly . Adora sighs. She knew Catra was only teasing, but she snapped anyway. "Sorry . Iwasnt blaming you, it's just- a lot to suddenly be dealing with, especially without you here. Iknow this is just what your life is like,"Catra apologizes softly . Adora stares at her ceiling in shock, processing an *apbgy* from Catra, especially an unnecessary one.

"Im sorry , too. Ishouldnt have risen to that. I- are you really moving?"she asks, trying to clutch onto some kind of solid ground. Catra huffs a slightly strained laugh, but she lets out an oddly happy trill that sounds warped in tone by the phone call.

"Sorry , Melog is making biscuits on my stomach. He always does this when Im upset,"Catra explains, and suddenly the noises make more sense. Adora pictures Catra, flopped out across her little twin bed, with Melog kneading on her stomach, and she actually smiles at the image.

"Yeah, Im really moving. Ihave plenty saved up from living the way I do. Im not worried about having two rents briefly . Id rather do it than have to sacrifice my privacy like this,"Catra tells her . A deep rumbling is working its way over the call now, a sound obviously not originating from Catra even distorted by the phone call. Adora chews on her lip.

"Is it too soon for me to say anything?"she asks. She knows Catra will catch on to her meaning. There is a sharp intake of breath on the other end of the line.

"Have you thought about it before now?" Catra asks, softly . Adora actually scoffs at that.

"Only from the moment you unblocked my number . I still don't really know how to sleep without you. I know you might still need to find a way to stay closer to set during the week but I'd like to *be* with you again," Adora explains. The other end of the line is silent for several moments.

"You want to ask me the question?" Catra asks. Adora pauses, not sure what Catra actually wants from her. She thought she was perfectly clear about her intentions. "Maybe I need to hear you say it," Catra adds, her voice soft. A smile breaks out across Adora's face.

"Catra, my love, would you do me the honour of going apartment hunting with me?" she asks. The purr that comes down the line in response is *definitely* Catra's.

--

CATADORA @ *@ftf_inthe_ink • 5d*

now we all know: @adoragrayskull what was up with that acceptance speech when Heartstrings won album of the year?

Catra @catra_ • *Monday* • *Reply to @ftf_inthe_ink*

@ftf_inthe_ink Adora will never see this so you get the mean one: she knew I was there, I came to see her , and we were patching

things up. Im only telling you out of courtesy for not outing me. You werent a massive piece of shit when u could have been and that’s rare in LA

CATADRA N *@tf ntheink • Mnday 2 • Eyg to @atacya*

@catacya wow didnt know getting insulted did it for me but if it doesnt work out with adora step on me?

Catra *@catacya • Mnday 2 • Eyg to @tf ntheink*

@tf ntheink Sorry but we promised ourselves to each other in third grade and that hasnt changed

---

CATADRA N *@tf ntheink • Mnday 2 • Eyg to @atacya*

@catacya wait fucking seriously how are yall this cute on TOP of being hot give us SOMETHING

TH LESBIANS ARE WIN *@dongstan • Mnday 2 • Eyg to @tf ntheink*

@tf ntheink omg tiffany using her powers for good. ty for the food

--

Adora Gyskill *@adoragyskill · Tuesday*

@catacya Icant believe you told the internet that we became life partners in third grade



Catra *@catacya · Tuesday* *Replying to @adoragyskill*

@adoragyskill Icant believe you released an entire song about how bad you wanted to fuck me in high school

---

Adora Gyskill *@adoragyskill · Tuesday* *Replying to @catacya*

@catacya The hook is "We run in parallel"Iwould argue the main point of the song is how pathetically Iwas yearning for you then

---

Catra *@catacya · Tuesday* *Replying to @adoragyskill*

@adoragyskill No one is buying the bullshit youre selling, princess. The internet knows youre nasty . Nice new screenname btw

---

Glimmer! *@glimbom · Tuesday* *Replying to @catacya and @adoragyskill*

@adoragyskill @catacya Are you two even at your own apartments or are you flirting via twitter from the same couch

---

Catra *@catra • Tuesday 8:47 PM to @adoraskull and @gerbob*

@gerbob We're not even in the same zip code rn calm down. Im on set. But hey want to come pick up the horde of your fans someone left outside of my apartment? They're upsetting my cat

---

Glimmer! *@gerbob • Tuesday 8:47 PM to @catra and @adoraskull*

@catra is that a joke?

Catra *@catra • Tuesday 8:47 PM to @adoraskull and @gerbob*

@gerbob What your life? No Melog has gone through two of his scratching posts this week. Im about to fucking join him

---

Glimmer! *@gerbob • Tuesday 8:47 PM to @catra and @adoraskull*

@catra You have a cat

Adora Oyskull *@adoraskull • Tuesday 8:47 PM to @catra and @gerbob*

@gerbob @catra He's really sweet and he's leashed trained. Catra rescued him from the street cuz she's a secret softie

---

Catra @catra • Tuesday, 5 Feb
@adoragayskull and @bmom

@adoragayskull @bmom He isn't TRAINED you dont train a cat. He just enjoys going on dignified walks around the neighbourhood with his bitch mom. Something I can never do again

---

Glimmer! @bmom • Tuesday, 5 Feb
@catra and @adoragayskull

@catra Catra add me back on snapchat so I can send you a video of how hard I'm laughing

---

Catra @catra • Tuesday, 5 Feb
@adoragayskull and @bmom

@bmom So you can make a fool of yourself? Pretty sure your old tweets about me already did the job but thanks for the offer, Sparkles

--

Glimmer ✨

Send contact details >

You have to break up

You tweeted it

And I DELETED it this is war Grayskull I hope you realize that

It’s the internet deleting means nothing

Hang on Catra’s calling me

Tell her to prepare for battle

Your shipname is sparklekitten

What

Your and Catra’s shipname is sparklekitten. Damn they’re fast

Catra’s texting me links to fanedits already

I’m going to kill your girlfriend and then our fanbase

Some of these are from when you first tweeted about her

Sorry Glim it’s way too late for you

Treason

--

Adora gets a call while she is in the middle of a songwriting session with Spinnerella. She has her phone muted, but Catra’s calls are set to always go through.

“I have to take this,” Adora apologizes, stepping away from the microphone to take the call in the corner of the room. “Catra?” she questions, unsure. Catra should be filming right now, and with the exception of Friday, she never calls from set unless she has managed to get total privacy. Despite their relationship being public now, they don’t want their *conversations* to be.

"Where are you right now?" Catra asks, her voice an edge unsteady . Adora's heartbeat picks up.

"I'm in the studio. Are you alright? What is going on?" Adora questions, biting her lip. She hears Catra lean away from the phone for the moment, softly cursing. A moment later she returns.

"The shoot got rearranged, some tech issue bullshit. I came home early and I— There' s a lot of people here, Adora," Catra explains, her voice quiet like she is afraid of being overheard. Adora understands the situation instantly. Catra's old fears are rising again, no matter how many years it has been since they last saw Shadow.

"Did you make it inside?" Adora asks her , already mentally running through her options. She feels a hand on her shoulder, Spinnerella looking at her with concern, but Adora waves her off despite knowing the distress must be obvious on her face. Melog's scratchy mew answers her question before Catra does.

"Yeah. I'm sitting on the floor of my bathroom. I can still hear shouting on the street. They aren't angry or anything — well, there is a bible-thumper, but — I'm just scared. I don't know why ," Catra replies. Her voice is a bit stronger than it was at the start of the call, wavering less, but it's far from solid.

"We both know why. It' s nothing to be ashamed of, Catra," Adora replies, maybe a bit too forcefully from the way Catra draws in a sharp breath. Adora sighs, resting a hand against her brow to think. "It' s been five days. They aren't going away ," she reasons, thinking out loud.

"Real comforting, thanks, Adora," Catra drawls, but sarcasm is a good sign, at least. Adora has seen Catra so far gone she couldn't make jokes before. She never wants to see Catra like that again.

"I'm making an argument here. I know it would be a shitty commute, but I've never had any problems getting spotted at my apartment. If you want to take Melog there, I can meet you in two hours. It will

take you at least that long to get there with traffic anyway. f we need to, we can get you a hotel near set, but Melog and all your stuff would be somewhere safe,"Adora argues, motioning with her free hand as she talks despite the fact that Catra cant see her .

She accidentally collides with Spinnerella's arm as she gestures, but she does not look up from where she is staring determinedly at the wall like that will help convince Catra. She knows she just did it again —just got *intense* again —and that probably is not the ideal thing in this situation, but Catra always said she loved her intensity. Hopefully, it was grounding instead of overwhelming. The breathing on the other end of the line is shaky for several moment as Catra thinks it over.

f Ok. T ekme your address and ll head over once Imanage to get all of Melog's stuff out to my car through the crowd. ust - leave your phone on, please. ll be teking,"Catra tells her . Adora lets out a sigh of relief. She hates to see Catra like this, but the worst part is she understands her fears —she feels them to. t will be awkward and rough until they find somewhere new, or at least for the nekmonth while Catra finishes filming, but they will be together.

fcan leave the call on speaker . m in a writing session with Spinny right now, it's no big deal if you listen. t might help with my inspiration to know youre listening, actually . ust mute your mic unless you need something, Iguess. Idont really want you to be alone right now either,"Adora tells her .

f Okay ,"Catra manages, her voice small and choked.

--

'Are we really doing this?"Catra asks her . Adora pauses, pulling back to look down at her questioningly . Catra rolls her eyes and

threads her hand into Adora's loose hair, directing her back down to her neck. "We are definitely doing *this*, I meant the house," she clarifies, breath hitching as Adora's hands make their way beneath the edge of Catra's loose band shirt. Not a Rebellion shirt, to be clear, and Adora is going to have to *do* something about that later, but-

"We can afford it outright and it's the only way we get privacy. We have had this conversation four times, Catra," Adora points out between kisses as she makes her way down the length of her neck. She is not sure why Catra is bringing this up after she pulled Adora against her, encouraging Adora to press her up against the bedroom door, the final pieces from Catra's apartment still scattered around them after an awkward night move.

They needed to wait until after shooting was done for the day, and the dark provided them some reprieve from the gaggle that has become a fixture at Catra's place. Adora's apartment is a bit small for the both of them, truthfully – both her and Catra were used to living with the bare minimum of what they needed, and they didn't break that habit when they broke up - but it is only a temporary solution. It has worked fine for the last week that they have been forced to make it work, at least.

Hopefully it won't be much longer. Even after hitting major roles, Catra could never justify having two places when she was on her own, not with how they grew up. Now, a house near Adora's studio in private neighbourhood not only feels right, but it is pretty much the only true solution left. Catra can rent suites and extended stay locations near her film sets like actors usually do, knowing Adora is home and taking care of Melog for her if she cannot make herself do the long drive back on shoot days.

"Maybe I just need to know you haven't changed your mind," Catra murmurs, ears pinning back with her admission – or maybe because on the way Adora's teeth graze her collarbone. Adora pulls back, ignoring the whine it earns her, and assesses her girlfriend. Catra is

plastered with her back against the bedroom door, jeans half undone and shirt askew, her expression tense.

Her tail is twitching the way it gets when she is containing herself, but from her demeanor it could be in response to Adora's touch or anxiety from the conversation she has decided to start in the middle of the make out she *also* started. Her eyes are focused somewhere around Adora's ribcage, carefully looking at not much of anything despite the flush on her cheeks. From under the bedroom door, Melog's paws peek out occasionally as he tries to make his way back inside the room they banished him from.

"I want to have a space that is ours, where we don't have to deal with all the bullshit that follows us everywhere else. I'm not backing out on you. If you're unsure, we can call the agent right now and tell them to cancel the offer. But no part of me is considering that unless you are," Adora tells her , watching Catra's reaction. Catra releases a shuddering breath, a smile tugging at the corner of her mouth as she listens. Slowly, the wrinkle in her brow flattens, and her tail begins to properly sway, sweeping playfully back and forth against the door.

"You can't say shit like that and leave a gap between us, princess," Catra tells her, angling her chin back in invitation. Adora lets herself relax at the sight of Catra eased after spending a stressful day putting in the offer and moving the last of her things.

Adora follows her invitation, pressing in to pin her against the door with a kiss and hands on her waist. Catra sighs happily into the kiss, body shifting to arch into Adora. After a long, deep kiss, Adora drops her head to press kisses under her jaw again, sensing more words are coming.

"Adora? Thanks," Catra murmurs. Adora tightens her grip, reveling in the way it makes Catra arch her back as her tail lashes, and shifts back up to kiss her properly.

"I love you, no matter what the world around us does," Adora promises her. Catra shudders in her grip, her eyes falling closed for

a moment. When she opens them again, they are dark with intent. "Take me to bed, Adora," Catra responds. Adora does not need further encouragement.

Chapter End Notes

I know in other countries foster kids are specifically children that have been removed from their families, but in America it is used for any child that does not have a legal guardian and is a ward of the state. Thus, Catra and Adora are both orphans and foster kids.
Parallel makes a return. Adora will never live that down - not until she releases something MORE sappy/horny at least. The reason Catra didn't think that song was about her is because it a) has a co-writing credit and b) they had known they would be together forever. She didn't realize how badly Adora was still yearning to actually BE together once they got out, so she assumed it was more of the co-writer's story and it just fit on the album about love.

The Studio

Chapter Summary

> f finally taking Catra to visit the studio felt weird, the cosmic chances of turning on Swift Wind and immediately being greeted by Found playing on the radio soothes her a bit. Tey both laugh about it, Adora finding the coil of worry in her chest unraveling at the rasp of Catra's laugh so early in the morning.

Chapter Notes

> Terms: A "comeback" is just when a group returns with new music. I initially used it several times in this fic and then edited it out to reduce confusion. Fan café are a thing the major labels have in Korea with idol-themed food & drinks and markings on the menu of each idol's favourite dish. Fans will go there in hopes and catching a glimpse of their favourite idol as they go to practice or w/e.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

f finally taking Catra to visit the studio felt weird, the cosmic chances of turning on Swift Wind and immediately being greeted by *Found* playing on the radio soothes her a bit. Tey both laugh about it, Adora feeling the coil of worry in her chest unraveling at the rasp of Catra's laugh so early in the morning.

t has been two weeks since their relationship has been made public to the world. Te first day of f Catra got from filming they dedicated to looking for a new place, and the second was for house negotiations. Now they are just waiting for the title to clear , and Catra cautiously asked Adora if she could see the studio earlier in the week.

t is three years overdue, perhaps, but there is no way Catra could have visited without being spotted before, not with the fan café always attracting a decent crowd regardless of time of day or year.

That doesn't *matter* anymore. There is no secret to keep, not between them. The world has known for two weeks and yet no one has kidnapped Catra out from their bed in the middle of the night.

Rebellion's music is still selling – selling better than *ever*, actually, with all the buzz around their romance – and Catra is still getting auditions. She may even be on the way to lining up her next role. Catra can visit without worry. Adora parks her car in the private staff garage and throws an arm across the passenger seat to stop Catra from getting out. Catra raises an eyebrow at her, but Adora just grins and shakes her head.

"Just wait," she tells her, getting out of the car herself and walking around so she can open the door for Catra. Fond amusement sparks in Catra's eyes and she lets out a trill, throwing one leg out of the car and exiting it dramatically - like a movie star, which she *is*. She is going to be at the Oscars in three weeks, after all. Adora watched her go over the suit options her stylist sent over last night and lost her mind just a little bit picturing Catra in any of them.

Fuck, Adora has it bad.

"I forgot how much of a gentleman you are," Catra purrs, leaning against Swift Wind's backseat door and crossing her ankles as she watches Adora close the passenger door and lock the car.

"I *couldn't* before," Adora complains, and maybe she would be bitter about it if she weren't so *happy* this morning. Catra smiles at her, lopsided with just a flash of fangs, and Adora feels her mouth going dry despite the fact that they are in a public parking lot and can't do anything. Okay, it's private, actually, but it's the same thing when it comes to the possibility of getting caught.

Adora has never been able to resist Catra, however, so she finds herself taking the bait and boxing Catra in against Swift Wind, her hands on the low roof on either side of Catra while she meets her in a slow, languid kiss. Catra uncrosses her legs, giving Adora the opportunity to press in closer, grip tightening on the car roof.

"Jah, I swear this thing is your second love," Catra manages between kisses, dropping one hand to rap lightly against Swift Wind's door. Her other hand comes up to fist in Adora's jacket, insistently tugging her closer.

"Nothing can compare to you, kitten," Adora promises between the kisses, her voice low. Catra shivers into the next kiss, but when it finishes, she pulls back and fixes Adora with a narrow-eyed glare.

"We ll have sex in the backseat before you call me that where it can be overheard again," she threatens, her voice totally breathless. Adora *f eels* her brain shut off, eyes glazing over as her gut clenches at *that* mental image. Catra laughs, light and amused, at the way Adora becomes completely useless in the face of her words.

"Not happening, princess. But we should probably head in before we get caught doing what I *am* willing to do," Catra tells her , raising a hand to lightly pat her cheek. She finishes the motion by leaning forward, pressing a chaste kiss against Adora's lips. Adora sighs, not quite disappointed, but also thoroughly unhappy to be breaking the moment.

Still, she is excited to actually show Catra around. They'll have plenty of time to kiss in places where Adora can call her whatever pet names she likes later.

--

Adora Sky ll @adoraskyll · 5d

Taking @catracyra to tour the studio today . When we got in the car they were playing Found on the radio. Some mornings it just feels meant to be <3

Catra *@catra • 6d ago • Reply to @adoragaslu*

She made me tweet this for her. Dont texk and drive children.

Frosta the Unconquerable *@frostedpcess • 6d ago • Reply to @catra and @adoragaslu*

@catra Adora texks and drives all the time

Catra *@catra • 6d ago • Reply to @adoragaslu and @frostedpcess*

@frostedpcess She uses hands-free, but Adora is a bad example in life. Shouldnt you be in school?

Frosta the Unconquerable *@frostedpcess • 6d ago • Reply to @catra and @adoragaslu*

@catra t’ s Sunday, Im home schooled, and Im meeting you there in an hour?

--

t is almost an adrenaline rush to walk past the fan cafe blatantly holding Catra’s hand. The security guards keep anyone from approaching them, but Adora waves through the windows as she sees multiple people inside scramble, some rushing towards the

glass while others reach for their phones. Catra just looks vaguely amused.

"I'm not waving at the people who drove me out of my apartment," she says, but she doesn't sound bothered. Those few days were incredibly stressful, and Catra has to spend some nights in a hotel near set now, but getting to wake up to Catra in her arms on the other mornings makes it all worth it in Adora's mind.

Adora squeezes her hand and Catra rolls her eyes, releasing it to wrap herself around Adora's arm instead. Even from *here* Adora can hear a gasp rise inside the café. It makes Catra snicker, hiding the motion behind her hand. Adora blatantly watches her, a flush of unknown origins rising on her face.

"One of them *cooed*. How tightly wound are your fans that this much affection makes them melt?" Catra asks, ear flicking towards the café as they finally reach the elevators.

"I mean, it looks like it's mostly high schoolers right now, and you remember how *we* were then," Adora points out, calling the elevator for them and stepping back to wait. Catra wrinkles her nose.

"I prefer not to remember a second of that, thank you. I was so stupid for you, it was such a mess," Catra recalls. Despite her words, her mouth twitches in a fond smile. Adora laughs.

"And you make fun of me for *Pearl*," she teases, leading Catra forward as the elevator doors finally open. She sees a wicked smirk cross Catra's face for a moment in the mirrored back wall of the elevator before Catra is turning to look over her shoulder. She times it perfectly, because of course she does. She steps through the elevator doors, tail whipping forward to avoid the doors and subsequently looping loosely around Adora's hip.

Adora feels a blush rising, but Catra is far from *done*. She makes eye contact with Adora in her reflection as the doors begin to shut behind them. A moment before they close and completely block

them from view, Catra's hand snatches forward and grabs the front of Adora's shirt. She hauls her towards the back of the elevator, pressing her up against the back wall with a bruising kiss. She has her hands on either side of Adora's head before the soft ding signals that the doors have finally closed.

--

gayg4rayskull @bestandom 6 days ago

No joke just saw #catradora start to makeout in the back of an elevator at @BrightMoonEntertainment HQ. Like shoved against a wall making out. They did it in full view of the cafe but the doors closed before I got a pic

---

gayg4rayskull @bestandom 6 days ago *replying to @bestandom*

Catra was hanging off Adora's arm before that when they were walking up. They're disgusting together I love it. Where's our next Parallel adoragrayskull huh?

CATDRA @bestandom 6 days ago *replying to @bestandom*

@bestandom WHY didnt you get footage I CANT BELIEVE I ISKPED THIS SUND AY AND MISSED THIS

Catra's tail) *fox of an • Sday* *Beg to* *@bestandom*

@bestandom Who was on top this is important

---

gay4grayskull *@bestandom • Sday* *Beg to @bestandom and fox of an*

fox of an Idk if Iwant to admit this but Catra

--

"And this is where we usually practice our choreo," Adora tells Catra, gesturing into the dance studio. Half of Rebellion is already waiting there, looking up as they enter side-by-side. Bow and Perfuma wave. Mermista does not move from her careful stretch position, but that one is a bitch so Adora does not blame her. Glimmer and Frosta are missing, but practice doesn't start for another few minutes anyway.

Half the day was supposed to be a practice day, truthfully, but they don't have any big performances coming up, so it was mostly just to stay on form. Adora managed to make some sad eyes at Angella and get the practice whittled down to just 2 hours before Adora is scheduled to go up and work on recording some demos for the new songs she starting writing once Catra came back into her life.

Truthfully, only about half of them were even about love, but Adora wasn't exaggerating when she called Catra her muse. She is almost Adora's window into the world. Catra is the person she filters her experiences through. Without her, it was a lot harder to write songs about those experiences since she didn't get to see Catra react to them too.

Glimmer comes in while Adora is laying out her jacket to give Catra a place to curl up against the wall while they practice. Glimmer raises an eyebrow, a teasing smirk barely containing the words clearly welling up on her tongue. Adora sends her an obvious *shtup* look while Catra settles on the jacket, balling herself up so she is facing the center of the studio, resting her head on her arms.

"Don't be insulted if I fall asleep while you're working," Catra warns with a yawn, directing her gaze to Adora, but speaking loud enough to fill the room, "We were shooting until one AM last night and I didn't get home until after three." Adora already knows that – she groggily woke for about five minutes when Catra slipped into the bed – so she knows that Catra is speaking for the benefit of the rest of the group.

Adora pauses beside her, leaning down to press a kiss to the top of her head and run a hand over her hair before she stands. She gets a satisfied rumble in response. Adora joins the rest of the group in the center of the room as Frosta, chronically late, finally arrives. Adora is glad today was just practice and running through some old choreo. She feels flustered knowing Catra is watching her. She knows Catra is placing no pressure on her, but she places it on herself, wanting to impress her girlfriend.

She keeps an eye on her out of the corner of her eye, noticing Catra's eyes slipping closed a few times and breathing a bit easier herself when they do. Whenever the song changes, Catra's eyes open again, not quite startling awake, but *close*. Near the end of practice, Catra moves, flopping on her back and humming along with the music now. The soft scratch of her voice, combined with all the exertion, makes Adora flush.

It is not until they are almost done, just three runs left, that Catra makes a thoughtless decision that thoroughly breaks Adora's mind. Softly, eyes slipping closed as she does so, she sings along with the song. She does it as if she is singing to herself, despite the way it feels like a calculated strike against Adora's concentration to hear

Catra singing *her* song, even if it isn't one of the ones she wrote for Catra.

Adora barely makes it through the choreography and her form is sloppy the entire time. When the song is done, she turns to glare at Catra. Catra still has her eyes closed, but it doesn't matter; Bow speaks up for Adora.

"Why didn't you tell us you could sing?" he asks, face tinged with awe as he turns to look at Catra's spot in the corner. Catra's eyes open, just short of flying open, and she turns her gaze on the group in the center of the room. Adora's glare has softened, just by virtue of the realization they are going to have to have *this* conversation now. Most of the group is looking at Catra with a mix of surprise, curiosity, and awe. Catra scoffs, using the action to turn her face away from the group's attention. Her ears are twitching back in discomfort at being the center of this kind of attention.

"Because I don't like music? That's Adora's thing. I was just trying to keep myself awake. I didn't mean to be distracting, or whatever," Catra shrugs, still turned off to the side. A dismissive flick of her ear signals the end of the conversation – to Adora, at least. The rest of the group presses on.

"Oh, you two should duet! It would be so cute!" Perfuma suggests, covering her mouth with her hands to hold in an excited squeal as she pictures it. Adora actually flinches, looking Catra's way apologetically. Catra meets her gaze and just rolls her eyes, flopping back against her jacket.

"I'm not joining your group. I prefer to lie for a living, thanks," Catra comments, dryly. Adora snorts at that, distinctly remembering when Shadow made that comment about Catra's chosen career. The fact that Shadow called Adora's passion a worthy art form while acting was treated as the choice of a degenerate was always a sore spot for Catra. Clearly she has come further on it, but Adora decides to jump in to save her girlfriend.

“Catra doesnt like to sing, okay? Not songs, anyway . When she does it is like, a stream of consciousness thing. Leave her alone,” Adora tells them, pointedly pulling up the music for their next song. The group drops it, but from the way they eye Adora and then each other Adora knows the conversation is far from over.

--

Glimmer! @glimbob • 6 days ago

They can BOTH sing this is so unfair

---

adora (exercise) @catswood • 6 days ago • Reply to @glimbob

NO this cant be true. Tell me it isnt true Icant handle this

Bow @glimbow • 6 days ago • Reply to @glimbob

Who is both? Glimmer your subtweets are getting out of hand lmao

---

bottomhutch @bellswateboy • 6 days ago • Reply to @glimbob

Uh the entirety of Rebellion is at BME right now with Catra right? Who else could this tweet be about

---

xem *@sotelodong • 5day1 • Edg to @bobmand @ebelswateboy*

@ebelswateboy NO if she joins Rebellion for the next comeback Ill lose my mind

---

praying mantis wife *@doassheath • 5day1 • Edg to @bobmand @ebelswateboy*

@ebelswateboy ADORA PUTHA TN ONLY REMEMBER Y our midnight songs gave me love all summer long!GUYS!

Mermista *@mar • 5day1 • Edg to @bobm*

She's going to kill you Glimmer

Glimmer! *@bobm • 5day1 • Edg to @bobmand @mar*

@mar She can TRY she cant call me out without admitting it

--

Glimmer and Bow take Catra on a tour through the boring office parts of BME no one *really* wants to see while Adora records her demos. The tour is bullshit and everyone knows it;they are just looking for an empty conference room to grill Catra in.

"We just want embarrassing high school stories," Glimmer assured her with a wicked grin as they lead Catra away. When they reunite, Catra's fur on her shoulders is a bit ruffled, which Adora can only imagine the reasons for, but she seems largely relaxed. Adora pulls her in with an arm around her waist and flexes her arm twice, squeezing her close. It is unspoken code. *Everything alright?* Catra answers by flicking her tail up, brushing it softly against where Adora's arm wraps around her back.

Mhmm. Adora presses a kiss to her temple and sends a grateful smile to Bow and Glimmer. They look a bit confused, but glance at each other and seem to decide to let it go with a shrug. It only took seconds, but in a few brushes of affection Adora and Catra had an entire conversation, and Adora is assured Bow and Glimmer didn't bring up Catra leaving again or go digging into bad memories.

They go up two floors, finding their way onto a small set where the rest of Rebellion is waiting. Catra eyes the small interview room with amusement, no doubt comparing it to some set she has seen – or just finding it quaint compared to a film set, perhaps – as she makes her way to lean against the wall and wait for them to be done. Catra doesn't usually do interviews, and though she will no doubt *command* this is merely supposed to be a short social video to post on the group's channel.

The call for quiet goes out as all of Rebellion settles in tiered seating on the middle of the set. Adora, being one of the taller members, usually does her best to sit in the back. She thinks that is a perfectly reasonable argument. Unfortunately, being the leader, she is often placed front and center. Today, she pointedly sits in the back between Perfuma and Mermista after she is directed to sit in the front.

She glares at Micah – just a little bit, she doesn't know if she could ever bring herself to be harsh with such a kind man – when he raises an eyebrow in response. Nepotism has benefits, because he sighs and lets it go when Glimmer sits in the chair he had indicated for

Adora to take. Glimmer shoots Adora a thumbs up over her shoulder and Adora shoots her finger guns back.

Unfortunately, when she looks up from sending Glimmer the look, she realizes the light is on and that whole exchange was recorded. She can already picture the gifs that are going to flood her replies now. Seeing gifs of her own reactions being used by others will never stop being weird – although not as weird as it still is to talk about *herself*.

Knowing she is on camera now, Adora launches into the traditional *This is Bow, here to answer your questions* speech, pausing for the other members to jump in at their parts and for their group greeting. As soon as she finishes, she looks expectantly to Micah, off camera but a known presence as he begins to address the group and individual members with fan-submitted questions.

Micah has done a good job filtering the questions this time, even though Adora *knows* what the nature of most of them has to have been. Aside from their recent single – which was *also* about Catra – there really is no other news for the group other than Adora's new and suddenly-public love life. Still, a lot of the questions end up being standard fare for fan-submitted prompts. The kind of things she used to get tweets asking about, and still would if she ever looked at her public mentions.

It has to come up eventually, though. Band members never get to hear the questions ahead of time – it is trusted that anything that could be a problem to bring up will be told to the manager before it can be an issue so they can make sure things are appropriately filtered in advance without losing the genuine reaction to the questions. For a long time, Adora's filter was absolutely anything about her past or love life. Micah makes eye contact with Adora a moment before he speaks, an unspoken warning to brace herself.

"Adora, was it easier to film a music video with someone you were actually involved with?" Micah reads off, still making semi-apologetic eye contact. Adora could sigh in relief. She shouldn't have doubted

him, but she was still worried about these questions. Micah picked the perfect question to give a fluffy, bullshit answer to or to give a more honest reflection if she was up to it.

Adora glances to her right to make eye contact with Catra from her spot a few feet away, still leaned against the wall with her arms crossed. Catra flicks her ear with a small shrug. She is unbothered by how Adora chooses to handle this. Adora turns towards the camera and smiles a little.

"Way easier, even if I didn't know what I was getting into. We all know my acting skills are a running joke. With Catra, it was just a natural day that happened to have cameras around it. The kiss was unscripted and unplanned. It was just something that felt right in the moment," Adora answers, shrugging a little at the end. There, plenty of honesty without exposing too much of the truth. She and Catra both decided the public never needed to know when they broke up or got back together.

She glances to her right again to catch Catra's eye and finds her tail twitching with amusement and eyes *dancing*, visible even squinting a little past the glare of the set lights. Adora knows that look – that is the look that led to there being a tweet publicly inviting thirst tweets on her account a few weeks back. Catra stands from the wall and circles closer to set, coming to a halt beside Micah and exchanging a look with him.

Micah smiles, almost excited, and motions her on. No one asked Catra if she wanted to be a part of this interview – she isn't a part of the group, after all – but her sudden appearance in the video will no doubt help its views. Apart from the occasional photos a fan or paparazzi has managed to catch of them, they have never made an official appearance together. Catra circles around the side of set to walk in around the back and drape herself over Adora's shoulders, leaning forward and whispering to the camera almost conspiratorially.

“Adora was on a two-week writing retreat leading up to the shoot, and I was a last-minute hire. The person in charge of hiring,” Bow does a stoic job of not shifting uncomfortably, “had no idea who I was or that we were dating. I just assumed that Adora had requested me when I got the offer. I was almost as surprised as she was when she walked onto the shoot on the day of and didn’t know I would be there. She spilled her coffee everywhere when she saw me,” Catra says, eyes dancing with satisfaction as she pulls back from her secretive lean forward.

“Hey, I didn’t spill it, I *dropped it*. There’s a—”

“There’s no difference. You were completely dumbstruck seeing Catra there. I could see that even watching from halfway across the set,” Frosta cuts in, waving her off. She turns to look at the camera. “They are *disgusting*,” she complains, whining just a little. Her bandmates laugh with her—and at her, a bit—but Adora merely shrugs because she knows she has no real argument. Catra’s answering purr is light enough Adora wouldn’t pick it up without being able to feel it running through her shoulders.

“You’ll understand one day, icicle,” Catra promises Frosta, pulling back to slip out of frame again. As she pulls back, her hand lingers on Adora’s shoulder, squeezing lightly before falling away. Catra slinks back out from under the lights of the set, a smug smirk in place, apparently satisfied with how she has exposed Adora. Frosta pulls a face at Catra’s words, but at least she doesn’t retch. Perfuma jumps to assure her she is young and will find love one day, completely derailing the rest of the interview more than Catra already has.

Micah manages to wrangle them back on topic, and after a few more questions, they reach the end and give their practiced sign off. The moment cut is called, Adora slips off her seat and goes to meet Catra against the wall. Catra watches her approach with amusement, her tail flicking smugly when Adora raises a challenging eyebrow and places a hand on the wall beside her head to let her lean in closer.

"Thanks for that, it's the only thing I'm going to get questions about from now on," Adora tells her, but they both know she isn't actually upset.

"And now they will be too caught up on the drama of it to ask the more invasive questions. *You're welcome*," Catra responds, still smug, tail sweeping out to wrap around the back of Adora's legs.

"If you two start making out in front of me, I *will* expose your secrets on Twitter," Frosta threatens from behind them. Adora narrows her eyes, glaring indistinctly at Catra's left ear, but she pulls back. Catra's face makes it obvious that she counts Adora's withdrawal as a win in her favour. She strolls forward, raising one hand to play with Adora's collar while she looks up at her with smug satisfaction.

"Don't worry, we will have plenty of time together *later*. Sooner, if you want to head back to Swift Wind now," Catra promises.

Well, shit. Maybe losing isn't so bad after all.

Chapter End Notes

> We all know AJ kills it, so yes Catra can sing in this AU too, she just refuses to do so in public because of Shadow. She likes to hum/sing to herself as she works around the house sometimes.

The House

Chapter Summary

> Catra snorts, short and derisive. "No, I liked it. I liked it the instant you posted that picture of you getting it, laying facedown and shirtless. Do you know how much it pissed me off to see that picture and know I wasn't the only one looking?" Catra asks, and even now, the ghost of her righteous fury can be heard. Adora flushes, thinking back to the photo Glimmer had taken and posted for her just before the artist wrapped her new piece.

Chapter Notes

> Hey here's a fun fact: don't give milk to cats. They, like pretty much every species except a minority percentage of humans, are lactose intolerant once they reach adulthood.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"To the end of a shitty shoot!" Catra calls happily, raising her glass.

"To friends!" Scorpia calls back in reply, meeting her for the cheers happily. With no drink to join in on the motion, Adora salutes instead, which makes Catra snort just before she takes her sip. The sound makes Adora's chest clench with fondness. Perfuma, also a designated driver for her girlfriend, just claps happily.

"Aw, you didn't wait for us?" Glimmer asks, pouting a little as she slides onto the bench seat next to Catra. The rest of Rebellion trails behind her.

"Don't worry, Sparkles. From what I hear, you're a lightweight. You will have plenty of time to get wasted before I'm even buzzed," Catra assures her, cocky as she elbows Glimmer lightly. Glimmer retaliates by moving to pull her tail - like a *child*, Adora would point out - but

Catra dodges by practically rolling into Adora's lap. Her drink sloshes, threatening to spill, but it luckily stays off their jeans.

"Introducing you two was a mistake, but getting you both near alcohol is a terrible idea," Adora sighs, her arms coming up to wrap around Catra's waist as Bow leans around Glimmer to shoot Adora a sympathetic look in return. He is also a designated driver tonight, though Catra is probably right that when they all head home she will be, at the most, buzzed while Glimmer will be drunk.

"I still don't get why we couldn't go to that boozy ice cream place. They have regular ice cream, too, and half of us aren't drinking," Frosta complains as she sits opposite them in the VIP booth. Normally, people under twenty-one aren't allowed in this club, but for Rebellion, the manager has made an exception. Frosta has a black cross on her hand that she eyes with disdain.

"Because it's lactose, icicle. I'm a magicat, I'm tired of bitchy coworkers and long commutes, and I want to have a good time with my friends and their weird dance team," Catra shoots back, tone teasing and playful. She really is in a good mood. Her shoot wrapped this afternoon and she wanted to go out to celebrate.

With Scorpia the only member of Frght-Zn in town and Glimmer already on her invite list, Catra suggested they just go out with the group. Perfuma was guaranteed to come anyway since Scorpia is in town to visit her between shows on Frght-Z's international tour, and Bow would come if Glimmer did. That really only left Mermista and Frosta behind if she didn't extend the invite - plus Sea Hawk, as Mermista's ride.

Catra orders a round of drinks for the table. It feels odd still, even after a month, to be sitting in the middle of a club with Catra in her lap as they wait for the waitress to bring their drinks over. The VIP section is more private than the rest of the club, but if Adora keeps her eyes out, she can still see people pulling out their phones while looking towards Rebellion's table. Some of them just send a

message, others take photos. The true benefit of the VIP section is that at least no one can approach them.

It isn't *normal*. It isn't the same as when they were sixteen, not quite together but kissing in the dead of night and going on dates when they could sneak away without Shadow noticing for an hour or two. It isn't the same as when they were nineteen either, officially dating and living together, kissing happily in public with no worries as they set out on whatever free date they could figure out in LA that day between their part-time jobs, Catra's auditions, and Adora's training.

The fear of those earliest years is gone. Some of the freedom of that later year and a half is gone, too, and never coming back – the lingering stares from strangers is a stark reminder of that - but it's also freer in other ways. The two of them are sitting in the fancy club that Catra always wanted to be successful enough to get into when they were eighteen and starry-eyed.

It is freer because despite being *out* then, now they sit surrounded by friends who know not only who Adora and Catra are, but who *Adora and Catra* are together. Adora gets oddly choked up, watching Mermista swipe the drink Catra has to get a taste of her cocktail as Catra complains about getting secondhand contamination from Sea Hawk.

As Sea Hawk starts on an emotional speech about his weirdly detailed dental routine, apparently trying to dissuade Catra, Adora flags down a waitress and has her get another drink for Catra. Catra flicks her tail over her hands in a silent *thank you*, throwing her an easy grin that makes Adora's already-watery breathing catch. She can't resist it any longer. She pulls out her phone and begins typing as the waitress returns with Catra's new drink. Catra sips it as she peers down at Adora's screen.

"That's cheesy. It suits you, though," she comments, turning to press a kiss to Adora's cheek. Glimmer raises an eyebrow, trying to lean around Catra to see Adora's screen and failing as Catra strategically elbows her.

"What is she doing? T weeting about your love or something?" Glimmer asks, making a half-hearted grab for Adora's phone. She has barely gotten halfway through her first drink, but her coordination is already failing. She is going to be *gone* in another hour. t will be funny as long as she does not let Sea Hawk talk her into playing with a lighter again.

"Uh, no? Whenever she gets quiet and then pulls out her phone, it means she's writing a song. You've known her three years, Sparkles, how haven't you noticed? This is how all her songs are written. She does it in the middle of *sex* sometimes," Catra tells Glimmer . Glimmer was a breath before taking another sip, but luckily still firmly *bef oe*, so a spit-take does not go all over the table at Catra's revelation. t is close though, Glimmer putting her drink back down as she is overtaken by a coughing fit. Adora feels her face heat as she continues to type, resolutely not looking up at her fellow idols.

"That only happened twice," she mutters, far too embarrassed to defend herself further. She hears a crow of laughter from the other side of the table and does not unpack who it originated from.

"And it happens like once a week while we're still in the making out phase. You're such a sap," Catra returns, but her voice is soaked in fondness. Adora chances looking up to meet her eyes, her cheeks still blazing as Glimmer continues to cough in the background. There are plenty of drinks around the table, but no water to ease her way through Catra's unexpected announcement.

Catra's eyes are soft as they flick between Adora's phone screen and her face. Her gaze trails down from Adora's eyes, catching her blush, and landing on her lips. Adora has never needed more encouragement than that to kiss her girlfriend. She presses forward, meeting her slowly and lovingly, drawing it out for a long moment before she falls back against the booth seat with a happy sigh.

"Disgusting," Mermista comments, high-fiving Frosta without looking.

Adora doesn't care, not when Catra is looking down at her like that.

--

Adora Cyrskll @adoracyrsk • Eayl

Congratulations to my wonderful girlfriend @catracyra for the end of a long movie shoot 3 Y ou're such an inspiration in so many ways

○ ♥

Catra @catracyra • Stday 7 • Eng to @adoracyrsk

@adoracyrsk You know Il give it to you, you finally learned subtlety

---

Dummer! @gbobn • Stday 6 • Eng to @adoracyrsk and @catracyra

@catracyra Stop flirting via Twitter while Ideal with your movers it's disrespectful to the single among us

---

Catra @catracyra • Stday 6 • Eng to @adoracyrsk and @gbobn

@gbobn No wonder you've been single for so long if that's why you think flirting is. Need some tips? I will definitely spice things up for you if Ishow you my moves.

--

Luckily, the sellers let them do some work on the house while the title and sale were being finalized. They will need to do more work at a later date, but there will probably be a window where Catra has to live away for a shoot while Adora is on tour, so that becomes a *f tu* problem. They finalize everything on Friday after Catra's shoot, and on Saturday Catra puts Melog on his leash while Adora greets Glimmer and Bow at their apartment, and then the movers.

They take Melog to the beach because the stray is wary of strangers in his territory and thus far too stressed by the movers. They trust Glimmer and Bow will direct the movers well enough that they can fix any remaining issues when they arrive at their house that evening. Melog loves the beach, it turns out – far more than Catra does. He bounds across the sand, for once attracting more attention than Catra and Adora themselves.

t is winter , but winter in A , so there are plenty of beachgoers. They picked a less popular beach, so they manage to avoid crowds, but Catra is still forced to hiss and few times before *Mog* does when strangers try to approach them to pet him – not that he doesnt echo his mom dutifully, but it keeps the strangers from getting too close.

As they walk, Catra loops her arm around Adora's back, resting her head on her shoulder and rumbling softly as her fingers sightlessly trace the lines of the tattoo on her back. t isnt hard to do – Adora is in a crop top and the raised line of the scar it covers outlines the edge of the blade.

"I got so mad when you first had this done," Catra says, conversationally, tapping her fingers against the outline of the sword, as if there is any doubt about the subject matter . Adora feels herself frowning, glancing down at her girlfriend to find her placid and serene as they walk.

"Did you... not like it?" Adora asks, unsure. They've never talked about her tattoo before. She had it done at the end of Rebellion's

first tour, awhile after Catra left her. The sword referenced one of their singles, but it was also just for the fact that Adora is a giant lesbian.

Adora had always talked about getting a tattoo, and Catra would reply that she could see that being sexy or an utter mistake, depending on what she ended up getting. It has been on her back for so long that Adora hadn't really thought of it by the time Catra came into her life again, but now she suddenly feels a jolt of anxiety over it. Catra snorts, short and derisive.

"No, I liked it. I liked it the instant you posted that picture of you getting it, laying facedown and *shirtless*. Do you know how much it pissed me off to see that picture and know I wasn't the only one looking?" Catra asks, and even now, the ghost of her righteous fury can be heard. Adora flushes, thinking back to the photo Glimmer took and posted for her just before the artist wrapped her new piece.

"I, uh, wasn't thinking about that when I posted it. I just wanted you to see it. I didn't know if you would, but I knew Scorpia would at least tell you about it. It felt wrong to be doing it without at least *telling* you, but you didn't want to hear from me then," Adora explains, cheeks flushed as Catra's fingers continue to trail along the design.

Adora can practically feel her skin crawling from the blatant intent in the touch, a thrum of energy gathering beneath her skin that she does her best to stamp down. Melog glances back over his shoulder at them, as if *judging* her. Catra gives an almost-inquisitive trill, surprised and questioning.

"I didn't know that. I assumed you just wanted to show it off. Fuck, the comments on that photo- I got so worked up about other people seeing you like that, talking about you like that, when even I *couldn't*. I wanted nothing more than to be in your life, but it was so painful before." Catra trails off, her ears pinning back as she raises her head from Adora's shoulder to turn it away, looking out towards the ocean.

"I was so frustrated at you, and myself, and the band since I blamed them for coming between us. And I was *frustrated* looking at that picture, because somehow you only got more ripped while we were apart," she adds, cheeks flushed. Maybe she is just trying to take the conversation to a more light-hearted place than it was tracking before, but the current thread is making Adora's own face heat as she, quite unsubtly, turns them around to walk them back in the direction of the car.

It will take awhile to reach Swift Wind again, but she needs to get them at least out of where they risk being overheard. Luckily, the wind has picked up and a lot of beachgoers seem to be abandoning the water and shore. It is too cold to be in a wet swimsuit, maybe, but Adora's internal train of thought is providing plenty of heat to her body.

"And then I read the *comments* on it, because I'm as much of a masochist as you are, apparently," Catra adds, rolling her eyes. She sneaks a glance at Adora, smirking at her flush. "I got so jealous I damn near tore up my apartment just to get my frustration out. I, uh, I actually went to the local thrift store and dropped twenty on a beat-up armchair so I had something to sink my claws into," Catra admits, her own face flushing as she fixes her gaze on the pier in the distance before them.

Adora turns, startling at the admission enough for Catra's arm to fall away from where it is wrapped around her. A flash of panic shades Catra's face before she wraps her arms around herself, continuing to walk with her head hung just a little.

"No, hey, *Catra, wait*," Adora calls, rushing to catch up and wrap an arm around Catra's waist, pulling her back flush against her chest. Catra draws in a sharp breath, Melog turning and flattening his ears at the sound. He surveys the two of them, Adora blinking down at him in surprise of Catra's shoulder. After a moment, Melog seems to decide that Adora isn't a threat to Catra and turns back to face forward, his tail flicking - just like Catra's is, thudding against her leg lightly.

"You really had to do that?" Adora asks, voice soft as she curls around Catra's back to rest her head on her shoulder. Catra lets out a slow breath, still a little stiff in her arms, but relaxing slowly.

"Yeah," she admits softly. "I was kind of a wreck after leaving. My emotions were all over the place. The delay to go buy the thing was about as close to self-restraint as I got back then. Otherwise I would've just torn apart my kitchen cabinets and lost my security deposit," she admits.

Adora tightens her hold, turning her head to press an insistent kiss to the side of Catra's neck. Catra practically sags in relief against her, like she thought Adora was going to judge her for *leaving* her and needing her after Adora failed to be there for her.

"I'm sorry. For being so focused on trying to get us somewhere that I completely lost sight of *us*. And I'm sorry for posting a dumb thirst trap to try to get your attention," she says, adding the final bit for some levity. Catra chuckles lightly in her arms, turning to face her. Her own arms come up, draping over Adora's shoulders as she looks up at her with a spark in her eyes.

"In your defense, it worked. I thought about that whenever I needed an *extra push* for the next month at least," Catra chuckles, pressing in to kiss her. Adora fights her brain shutting off for a valiant two seconds before she gives in to Catra, melting into her kiss and pulling her in hungrily. Luckily Catra, at least, has enough presence of mind left to remember that they are on a public beach before they can really start making out. She pulls back, the spark in her eyes fanned up to a flame now.

"Let's head home. The movers should be done with the heavy lifting, and I want to get you *alone*."

--

The movers are done, but time *alone* is still a long way off. Adora is grateful to Glimmer and Bow for helping, but she kind of just wants to unpack their linens and call it a day. She can tell Catra is thinking the same thing with just a glance in her direction. Luckily, neither Glimmer nor Bow seems to be able to read their thoughts as easily. They stick around, despite only having been asked to cover for them with Melog, helping to unpack the boxes that the movers brought.

All their furniture has been arranged as they planned, even if they might need to move a few things later. The place still feels oddly bare, not enough furniture carried over from Adora and Catra's tiny, standard-of-living apartments to fill a four-bedroom house. They have next to none of the equipment for their planned home gym or Adora's music studio, so those rooms sit almost entirely empty as they set up the last few sundries and *finally* get the bed set up in the guest room.

Their new bed for the master bedroom will be arriving later in the week, now that they actually have room for a king. They can sleep in the guest bedroom for a few days. Adora is sitting on the floor of the living room, ostensibly trying to sort out the cables behind the entertainment center, when a weird sense of melancholy at the empty house hits her.

It is less about seeing the house empty and more about the realization of how little they have—how little they have always had, and continued to have even when they could afford better. It took the need to outrun their fans before they even let themselves consider a home, despite the fact that both of them could have afforded one on their own by then. Adora is pretty sure she never would have bought a house without Catra, if only because she couldn't have lived with so much room without feeling the ghost of Catra's empty space all around her.

Pulling out her phone, Adora strains her ears to listen for the sounds of Glimmer and Catra bickering upstairs over the clattering of Bow

putting away dishes in the kitchen. She ends up absorbed in her phone, typing away slowly, lines coming to her one at a time with a breath between each of them. Catra's voice grows louder and then fades again as the words flow forward.

After a few minutes, a breath comes and is never released, cursor freezing on the screen as no more lines come to her in the heat of the moment – or the weird, sustained sadness of the moment. Whatever. Adora saves the note, scrolling through her list and realizing she has a few dozen songs saved up in her notes, waiting to get fleshed out in songwriting sessions. That doesn't even count the ones she has already gotten to work on in a songwriting session with one of the other group members or Spinnerella, or the ones that have made it to a music and production session with Netossa.

In the distance, Catra's laugh bounces off the walls of their new home. Adora exits her notes app and pulls up Twitter instead.

--

Adora Sky *@adorasky* • *1d*

Might be a quick turnaround, but a lot of inspiration has entered my life lately.

Where in South Dakota is Carmen *@adoosf_anpage* • *1d*
Replying to @adorasky

NEW MUSIC! NEW ALBUM!

Gloria and Cats *@bebsl_esbian • 3d ago Edited to @adoragaysku*

ADORA YOU CANT JUST TWEET SHIT LIKE THIS

Katastrophe *@bebsl_esbian • 3d ago Edited to @adoragaysku*

This is either a comeback an or engagement announcement and Iam LOSING MY SHIT either way

Chapter End Notes

Catra will never stop baiting Glimmer over her old thirst tweets ok she doesnt let things go. Glimmer and Bow are not together in this AU - yet. They live in a two-bedroom apartment together and its lowkey killing both of them. They get together during Rebellion's third album release.
Agh Icant believe this fic is almost over it has been so fun. Thanks for reading you guys <3

The Oscars

Chapter Summary

> "I kind of hate these things," Catra whispers in her ear as Adora pulls her close for photos. "I thought the Oscars would be cooler than the film festivals, but it turns out it's just more," she complains, but her smile for the cameras doesn't falter. She is the image of cool, content confidence. Adora squeezes Catra's arm in what she hopes is subtle reassurance.

Chapter Notes

> Like in all my fics (and canon), magicats are really rare. It complicates things for Catra professionally cuz of exoticism. Adora's wearing the wish dress but make it thotter. I also haven't watched the Oscars since high school at the least so if I got the award order wrong - oops, but I don't actually care lol. First I do a sports au despite not liking sports, now I do an idol/actress au despite not watching movies.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"No," Catra says, batting Adora's hand away as she reaches to fix Catra's bow tie. Adora raises an eyebrow at her and Catra just smirks, the flash of her fangs showing clear *intent*. "The look is *we just had sex in this bitch*," Catra explains, turning away in smug satisfaction to look out the window.

Adora could point out that her white dress is immaculate, as is her hair in its complex braid, while Catra's black suit covers a lazily-buttoned dress shirt and completely undone bowtie, her hair artfully tousled. Only *one* of them looks like they have been up to something, but then again, Catra always was the troublemaker amongst them.

"Is that the direction you gave your stylist?" Adora asks instead, because this is *Catra's* award show after all, and the least she can do is let her girlfriend look like a mess if she wants to. Adora likes the look personally, but they are going to stand out a lot. Then again, they already will just by the virtue of who they are.

"Close. I said 'messy lesbian, like I just had sex in the back of the limo, but make it classy'," Catra corrects, throwing her another smug smirk as the car pulls to a halt at the red carpet. "You ready to show us off, princess?" Catra questions, holding out her hand. Adora takes it instantly.

--

Despite having walked red carpets for music awards, Adora feels awkward at the Oscars. She is used to having Rebellion all around her, a crowd of excited energy she can blend into if needed. She and Catra attract attention just by virtue of who they are. Adora also feels an odd need to impress, knowing this isn't her world. She just wants to do what she can to help Catra enjoy herself at a place she has dreamed about reaching since childhood.

"I kind of hate these things," Catra whispers in her ear as Adora pulls her close for photos. "I thought the Oscars would be cooler than the film festivals, but it turns out it's just *one*," she complains, but her smile for the cameras doesn't falter. She is the image of cool, content confidence. Adora squeezes Catra's arm in what she hopes is subtle reassurance.

Despite what it means to have made it to the Oscars, the red carpet is a lot, and Catra has never enjoyed being the center of attention the way Adora does. Catra wants singular and devoted attention, from one or two people, not a hundred blood-thirsty reporters and photographers calling after her constantly. They make it through the

photos, and despite it being the last thing either of them want to do, let themselves be called over by a reporter. They decided before coming they would get one good interview in before they let themselves flee the carpet and make their way inside the theater.

They haven't made any public statements aside from their – even Adora can admit, disgustingly domestic – tweets and singular IG Q&A video since they publicly acknowledged being in a relationship with each other. They are already walking towards the reporter calling them over when a green hand enters their field of view. Catra nearly startles, turning to her left and pulling Adora, currently hanging off her arm, with her.

"Why are you down here?" Catra questions, incredulous, despite the microphone now being held out to her. Two assistants flutter around the show's host, one aiming a camera while the other, a pink fae so short she might not even be in frame, holds the microphone up for Catra to speak into.

"Expanding my host duties, darling! Everybody is down here, looking gorgeous and tempting, and you expect me to wait until the show? No, I'm doing red carpet interviews with the best-of-the-best to get this party really started!" Double Trouble tells Catra, dramatically gesturing as they speak. Their grin is teetering somewhere between shit-eating and threatening, but Adora is *pretty* sure that is just their face.

Catra worked with Dorian *Gretal*, and according to Catra they have a "hot and cold" relationship with each other. She still mused that D would be an entertaining host, at the least, when they first discussed Adora coming as Catra's date. Adora hadn't been expecting to actually *meet* the actor.

"Alright, kitten, you ready to get this party started? I have *questions* for you. The people are curious," D says, their smile dripping with dangerous intent. Adora has to repress a violent twitch at hearing someone else call Catra that. Her grip on Catra's arm still tightens dangerously, and she doesn't miss the way it makes Catra smirk

even as she rolls her eyes at D s statement. At least it doesnt seem like they *intended* to be derogatory, even if that is usually the intent when other people call Catra that.

"For you? An exclusive. The only one we give tonight," Catra promises. Her smile has a bit too much of her fangs in it. Adora realizes that however they feel about each other, D and Catra are a dangerous combination. Not that it will necessarily be bad – Catra and Glimmer are often the same way – but it does make her eye the other actor carefully.

"Excellent! Im not going to bother you with empty flattery about *tation* , we both know you were stunning and you dont need it," D says, clapping their hands together . Catra just inclines her head in acknowledgement. "I'll give you sixty seconds to talk about any projects you have coming up and then we can get to the *joy* part," they instruct, tapping the head of the pink fae holding Catra's mic. She raises it a little higher, wings quivering – if she is anything like Catra, it is from contained irritation.

"My next film hasn't been publicly announced yet, so I can't say much about it, but I can say that I'll be playing the lead role and it will be a queer story . A Sundance type film, but the kind of role I'm passionate about, and I can draw on my own experiences to give it the emotion it deserves. I'm excited for it, although I'm looking forward to having the next three months of f with my partner before filming begins," Catra lists of f.

Adora watches her as she speaks, surprised by the blend of authentic Catra mannerisms and phrasing she uses with the poised confidence of PR speak bullshit. Adora was expecting a solid mask tonight. Maybe Catra truly can't be bothered with it – her personality has been shining through on her Twitter lately without any repercussions thus far. Maybe she's just that excited about the role. She called Adora the moment she got the offer, ecstatic to finally get to play a lesbian, especially in such an emotional role.

t has Oscar bait written all over it. Coming-of-age, coming to terms with oneself, and the love interest dies before things can get too heated, dont worry . Another lesbian tragedy, sure, but it will be such a fun role," Catra had gushed, excitedly . She cant say all that now , but maybe those words are still simmering beneath her skin. Maybe that's why she gives the obvious segue, to avoid saying too much. Catra usually has an impressive amount of control over herself, but when it slips, it's always due to high emotions.

"Ah, your *partner*," the smiles, leers, maybe threatens? Adora cant really tell with them. To her surprise, Catra beams, reaching an arm out to wrap it around Adora's waist and pull her flush against her side. Adora fights the blush that wants to rise at the unexpected contact, smiling somewhat shyly at the . Apparently Catra is better at reading than she is, because the claps their hands together again and *coos*.

"You two are *sickening*, darling. The childhood sweethearts schtick? t makes me *gag*, but you wear it so well," the tells Catra. Adora doesnt understand this conversation in the slightest, she realizes. Catra grins, her tail swaying playfully behind her as she releases a low purr that Adora highly doubts the microphone can register.

"What can I say? found what I wanted young. Good thing, too. t would have been such *work* to find her when she was already married at thirty and have to steal her away from the picket-fence family she had built," Catra says. Adora feels herself blushing, not really sure what to do with *any* of that, except sit in the realization that Catra believes that no matter when they met, Adora would have been *the* for her.

"I need my phone," Adora mutters to herself. She has it, kind of, but it is inside Catra's suit jacket right now , and she isnt so shameless as to reach inside Catra's pocket and start typing a note in the middle of an interview.

"And what does that mean, darling?" the asks, angling their body towards her with their question. An excited spark is in their eye,

ready to drag Adora down whatever corridor she has opened with her mindless admission.

"It means inspiration has struck, which is to say *men*. And that we should be getting to our seats so Adora can finish her third album of lovestruck rambling," Catra tells them, dropping her arm from Adora's waist and taking a step back to offer it properly to Adora. They *pout*, their ears falling in their disappointment.

"But I haven't even gotten to ask you about your sex lives yet!" they protest, and Adora *thinks* they're joking, but she hurries to take Catra's arm before she can find out.

"Listen to the album," Catra placates, making Adora practically combust on the spot as she sends the camera a sheepish look and is thankfully, *mercifully* lead away by Catra.

"Are you trying to kill me?" Adora whines, just a little, when Catra has finally led them out of earshot. Catra's ear flicks towards her, an amused smirk still settled on her face.

"No, you're just that fun to work up, princess."

--

Watching the ceremony in person – to Adora, at least – doesn't feel that different from watching it at home. The angle is shittier, but she has been to enough music awards that it feels fairly normal. She is shocked by how similar it feels, truthfully. Nerves light her up every time someone mentions *Initiation* and Catra in the list of nominees, just the same as it does whenever someone mentions Rebellion or their album on stage during a music awards show.

tation wins its nomination for Best Original Screenplay, officially making Catra an actress in an Oscar-winner, if not one herself. Adora clutches Catra's hand when Best Supporting Actress comes up. She almost feels like she is more nervous than Catra, though she knows that isn't true. Catra sits, lounging in her seat patiently as she watches the announcer with curiosity, but her tail is almost quivering where it drapes over the edge of her seat.

The curious anticipation in her eyes has an edge to it. To the cameras, her mask is likely flawless, but Adora knows better. She knows they both hold their breath as the envelope is opened and Catra's name is read off. Adora is in tears instantly, turning and pulling Catra into an embrace without hesitation. She is so damn proud, nearly bursting with her love for the talented woman in her arms, but she also wants to pull her close and hide Catra's immediate instinctual reaction.

She gives Catra a few seconds to compose herself to how she wants to be seen by the world and then lets her go, still crying herself and smiling encouragingly as Catra stands to walk to the stage. Catra is largely collected as she makes her way to stage, but watching on the big screens Adora can see her hands shake a little as she collects the award from the announcer and turns to face the microphone.

"First, Ihave to thank the amazing cast and crew we had. A single actor's performance means nothing without talented cinematographers, colour graders, editors, and the like. We are nothing without your hard and often over-looked work, so thank you," Catra lists off, likely memorized and prepared.

Adora has heard the seed of the rant in this thank you – something Catra quickly realized after coming to Hollywood. Behind all the lights and glamour are hundreds of people working their asses off to make something usable. Catra's righteous fury at finding her dream no less manipulative and exploitative than corporate America had been hot and furious at the time. Adora isn't surprised she has included it in her speech.

Thank you to my partner , for always supporting me, even when I made it difficult, and for encouraging me to chase my dream. Ialso have someone Ihave to acknowledge, for always telling me that acting is an egotistical profession where you lie for a living. Thanks for your misplaced doubt, but Ive got the award to prove Im one of the best damn liars out there,"Catra finishes, with a derisive smile, and then she raises the award and walks away.

--

Nation loses its final nomination for Best Picture, but it doesnt really matter to either of them when Catra already has her award. There is an afterparty , but they dont go to it.

"Ithought Iwould care more, but now that Ihave the award –that' s all Ineeded. All Iwanted from this was to have that proof that Iwas good enough. Ijust want to be with you, now ,"Catra tells her when Adora questions if she is sure she wants to skip it. Adora has no response to that except to eagerly agree.

They end up on their couch when they get home. Adora takes her makeup off first and lets her hair down, kicking aside her shoes, but she doesnt want to take too long, so she stays in her slinky white dress. Catra stays in her suit pants and button down, but her jacket was discarded somewhere around the living room. Her bow tie vanished almost as soon as they got through the front door.

They sit on their couch, Catra splayed out on her side with her head in Adora's lap and Melog curled up on the cushion against Catra's hip. They watch the ceremony on the TV , fast forwarding through most of it, but making sure to pause whenever they remembered something entertaining happening, or when there was a mention of Catra or *Nation* . They watch Catra' s speech again. She looks

incredibly composed to the camera, the only tell her shaking hands as she takes the award.

"I was scared shitless I would drop it. I almost ended my speech with 'rot in hell,'" Catra tells her, not looking away from the screen as the recording of her raises the award and walks away, music starting to play in the commercial break.

"Do you think she'll watch it?" Adora asks, watching Catra's reaction. Her ear flicks as Adora's hands brush it as she strokes through Catra's mane, but she looks almost serene.

"I think it doesn't matter. It's out there, if she wants to judge me. But her judgement didn't stop me from getting there, or here for that matter. I have the award she always told me was junk anyway, and I have you. I could retire from movies vindicated and be a housecat for the rest of my days. I'm happy," Catra tells her, turning her head away from the TV to look up at her with open, honest eyes. Adora feels her breath catch, staring down at Catra in awe.

"I love you. And I would support you, if you wanted to just be a housewife, but I am so damn proud of you," Adora tells her, hand moving to cup Catra's cheek. She knows it was a joke – but she also wants Catra to know she loves her no matter what. Catra's eyes go just a little wide, her ears twitching, and then a smile starts to spread on her face that she has to fight to cover up with a smirk. Adora isn't fooled.

"I said house *cat*, but please tell me more about this word that you've introduced into the conversation now," Catra tells her, the smirk on her face growing wider as Adora's brain runs through the last few moments and *stops*.

"I- uh-" is the closest thing Adora gets to a reply, face heating as she realizes what she has said. Catra laughs, light and happy, as she sits up to press a gentle kiss against Adora's absolutely *useless* mouth.

t’ s okay. A conversation for later, yeah?Catra prompts, amusement dancing in her eyes. Adora swallows, biting her lip.

She should let it lie.

But not much later?s what she says, instead. A slow grin spreads across Catra’s face, no trace of her covering smirk left. She presses forward again, kissing Adora again, this time slow and loving.

Not *oh* ,”Catra agrees as she pulls back. A purr rises between them as Adora wraps a hand around the back of Catra’s head, pulling her back in with a need to respond to *that*, but no verbal language capable of conveying her feelings.

he kiss seems to do it, though, if Catra’ s answering gasp of delight is anything to do by.

Chapter End Notes

> And scene!Igot possessed by that scene with Catra showing up on Adora’s shoot without her knowing and it sprouted into this wonderful fluffy break of a fic. hanks to everyone who commented, you guys have been cracking me up and warming my heart 3
> **Edit April 2t,2** : ve just completed my edit of this entire fic. Iused to have some Post fic life"meta here, but m now working on adding the epilogue Ialways planned for this fic, so m removing the meta for now and ll repost anything that doesnt make it into the epilogue in my fic notes, which will go up on my tumblr after the epilogue is finished and will be linked in the final end note (Chapter 11’s). hanks for reading!

Epilogue (Bonus)

Chapter Notes

> Hey, remember this fic? Back when I was writing it, I had an epilogue planned, but I never wrote it because I got the idea for TOH 2 and wanted to move on. I've just done an edit of the entire fic, and now I'm adding on the epilogue I always wanted this fic to have!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They try locking Melog out so they can just focus on the stream, but he meows loudly at the door for the ten minutes leading up to the stream, so they leave the door open and just hope he won't fuck anything up.

"He's a good boy. He'll be fine," Adora tells Catra, cradling the stray to her chest as he purrs. Catra sends her an unimpressed look. Melog isn't usually allowed in Adora's home studio anyway, but he doesn't like being shut out of a room that both of them are in – except the bedroom. They installed a cat flap in the bedroom door and just lock it whenever they don't want him coming in. Melog has yet to figure out why the door doesn't always work and usually gives up immediately when he can't get in.

"He isn't an *angel*, he's a cat," Catra returns, wrinkling her nose a little. Adora has no idea what the means, but she doesn't really have time to ask because they're supposed to go live in two minutes. They get settled on their chairs as Adora doublechecks their camera and mic in preparation for the livestream to begin.

Rebellion's third album, *Possession*, comes out tonight. Rebellion has been doing promo work leading up to it, but they have been doing it without Adora. Catra's new movie starts filming in a week and until then, Adora isn't leaving the house. Even once Catra heads

out to live in a hotel near set, Adora is only going to be accompanying Rebellion to a select few interviews.

This album launch is her chance to really prove herself. Catra has already been proud of how she handled the single release, but Adora has a small package burning a hole through Swift Wind's glove compartment that she *wants* to give to Catra. She knows she can't do that until they get through an album release and Adora can show that she is putting them first.

She is going to be going along for parts of the press tour, but she is only going to be in half the interviews, mostly the ones requiring a live performance. She is going to take the time to rest, and she'll call Catra every day. Once they get through that – and once Catra is back from filming too – Adora thinks it will be the right time to finally try the proposal that Catra *hinted* she would accept three months ago, after the Oscars.

As a way to make up for the lack of interviews, Adora is going to do a few livestreams on Rebellion's channel, answering questions and interacting with fans. It's a lot more relaxed, something she can do out of her home with very little preparation. She can do things like add Melog to the lineup just minutes before they go live, and it still isn't stressful.

Melog is settled in her lap, just off frame, as Adora starts the stream. She greets everyone and then watches the chat immediately flood with exclamations over Catra's presence. Some of them are just key smashes and emotes, but Adora assumes those are also related to her girlfriend beside her. Adora grins as she leans back and throws an arm over the back of Catra's seat.

"Catra starts shooting in a week, so we're getting in every second we can before she has to leave. That's why I haven't been in the interviews this week. She'll be on the stream next weekend too, right before she leaves. Wanna introduce yourself, babe?" Adora explains, looking down at Catra and grinning to her. Catra rolls her

eyes, but she raises her hand and gives a half-hearted wave to the camera.

"Adora's girlfriend, you all know me. She'd get lonely without me here and we both know it," Catra tells the camera. Adora pouts at her and Catra purrs in amusement, seemingly satisfied with the reaction. Catra is well aware that she could have just hung out in the room while Adora streamed. She is actually here because she gives Adora someone to bounce off of and helps her keep her momentum going until midnight hits.

Adora watches the moment she pouted hit the chat as a wave of people start sending heart emojs and squealing. Catra snorts, sending Adora the look she always makes when her fans do something that Catra deems ridiculous. Adora rolls her eyes and reaches down, picking up Melog and holding him high enough up on her chest that the camera can see him.

"I'm pretty sure we've never posted pictures before, but this is our cat, Melog. He's joining us for this stream too," Adora tells the camera. The delay seems to be about twenty seconds, but when the stream catches up, the chat does exactly what Adora was expecting: it breaks.

Catra begins cackling.

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After the chat has been fixed – which takes a good *minute* for the lag to catch up with the sudden influx of messages – the stream pretty much goes as planned. Adora talks about the album while Catra watches the chat for her, letting Adora focus on talking about the project she has poured so much heart into without worrying about missing anything. They do a Q&A portion afterwards. Adora asks the

chat for questions and then watches Catra's eyebrows climb as she scans through the responses to find something she actually wants Adora to answer.

The chat, apparently, is roasting her for how horny the title track on the album is.

"It's not! It's about us, and that feeling when you're the only two people in a crowded room, and-" Adora starts to argue, her cheeks blazing. It absolutely is horny, but she is going to deny that until her dying day if she is ever going to manage to look Frosta in the eye. There are no obvious or explicit references to anything physical in the song, but it is loaded with implications. Adora brought it to Spinnerella with the intent of sanitizing, but Spinnerella – the *tator* – said it was prefect as it was.

"Is that why you had to take a break from making out to write it?" Catra asks, raising an eyebrow at her. Adora gapes at her. Catra's grin is smug and satisfied, her tail twitching on the sofa beside her as the chat, predictably, melts down. Adora can't read it well from here, but she can see it scrolling at record speed once Catra's words make it to internet.

They both agreed a long time ago not to talk about their relationship, but they also agreed that when they were together, they were just going to be *them*. Part of being them is roasting each other mercilessly. They might not be willing to answer questions about who sleeps on which side of the bed or what habit of the other's is most annoying, but Catra *loves* to fluster Adora.

She has succeeded. Adora realizes her gaping has only confirmed Catra's words. She snaps her mouth shut, scrambling for anything to save face. She doesn't come up with much. The title track released a week ago as a teaser for the album, and everyone has heard the numerous implications Adora slipped into the song.

"That's how I write half my songs," Adora eventually defends. "It doesn't *necessarily* mean something is horny. Rebellion's

discography would be way worse if that was the case. Half is maybe an exaggeration, but her point is made - made too well, because Catra's tail lashes as she raises an eyebrow at Adora, seemingly even more smug.

Adora flushes. Right. That didn't help. In fact, that just exposed her *one* . Why did she ever think having Catra on the stream with her was a good idea?

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Around eleven, with the album release drawing near and both Glimmer and Bow now in the chat, interacting with fans and roasting them in equal measure, they start playing some games with audience participation together. When midnight is about to hit, they'll do a countdown, but they have the majority of an hour to kill until then. Melog has delighted the stream every time he has appeared, but at this point it is late enough that even he has gone to sleep, curling up under the desk.

"Ooo, okay , chat has a good one. You ready, princess?" Catra asks. She has the chat completely hidden from Adora so they can give her song suggestions. When she settles on one, she hums the tune of it to Adora so she can guess them. The *hum game* is a thing online, but Adora honestly just thought it was a good test of her musician's ear. The one stipulation was that none of the songs could be Rebellion songs, because Adora would get those in an instant.

"Hit me with it," Adora responds. Catra *immediately* smacks her chest with her tail, giggling as Adora sighs and gives the camera a longsuffering look. Adora can't hold it for long, breaking and beginning to snicker along with her girlfriend.

"Okay , okay, shut up so Ican do this," Catra tells her after several moments of quiet laughter . Adora could point out that Catra *stated* it, but she also knows it most be hard to hum while laughing, so she places a hand over her mouth and looks to Catra expectantly . Catra snorts, but after a moment of clearing her throat, she begins to hum.

Most of the songs, Adora has gotten pretty quickly . One she never got, but when they looked it up, Adora had no clue what it was still, so she doesnt count that as a loss. This one itches at the back of her mind, a familiar melody that has her staring intensely at Catra as if that will help her figure it out. Catra looks like she is holding in a laugh, which is only making the notes she is humming a bit wobblier. t isnt helping Adora identify the tune at all, but she *knows* it, she just cant place it. Catra stops humming and Adora blinks imploringly at her.

That' s the end of the chorus, babe. Iknow for a fact that you know this song," Catra tells her , her voice quivering a little with laughter . Adora huffs, pouting a little as she crosses her arms.

I do, Ijust cant remember it, right now ," Adora tells her . Catra begins snickering again, glancing down at the chat and watching it for several seconds.

"Chat got it," she informs Adora. Adora sends the camera her pouty look. The chat was supposed to have her back. Catra forces her snickering down, looking back to Adora. "Redemption round? Ican hum it again if you arent ready to give up," Catra tells her . Adora is in no way ready to give up. She nods vigorously. Catra looks like she wants to laugh, but she begins humming again. Adora cant *place* it. She knows this song, but she cant figure it out-

"Oh, come on. *Be know how to play ,butnothing ke mand you* ," Catra sings, breaking into the actual lyrics. Adora feels herself light up, the song finally *clicking* .

"*Gt that perfect body ,butshe aint got the curves!* "Adora sings back, wanting to prove that she knows the song. Catra grins,

opening her mouth, and they both finish the song together, grinning at each other as the memories wash over them.

We got something better, got that real groove, baby

They danced to this at a club a few weeks ago. Adora really liked the upbeat tone of it. She completely forgot about it until this moment, but the song comes filtering back to her instantly once Catra gives her the words. When they finish, they both giggle, leaning into each other. Catra kisses her cheek, purring a little as her tail flicks, apparently delighted.

"I *told* you that you knew it," Catra tells her, nuzzling her cheek a little before pulling back to send Adora a fond look. Adora just shakes her head, still smiling.

"I knew that I recognized it, I just couldn't place it until you sang it," Adora tells her, rolling her eyes a little as she shoves at Catra's thigh. Catra's ears twitch as her eyes go a bit wide. Adora frowns, unsure of what just happened until she watches Catra turn her head to look at the chat. *Right*. They're live right now.

Adora can't read the chat, but she can see how fast it's moving as it utterly *eats down* in the face of Catra's singing voice.

Chapter End Notes

The song is Real Groove by Kylie Minogue.
This is only the second AU I wrote, so I didn't have established systems or anything, and thus this fic never got any fic notes. Now that I've edited it, I've posted fic notes over on my tumblr which also include insight into the edit.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!